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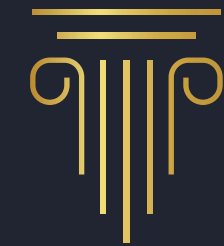
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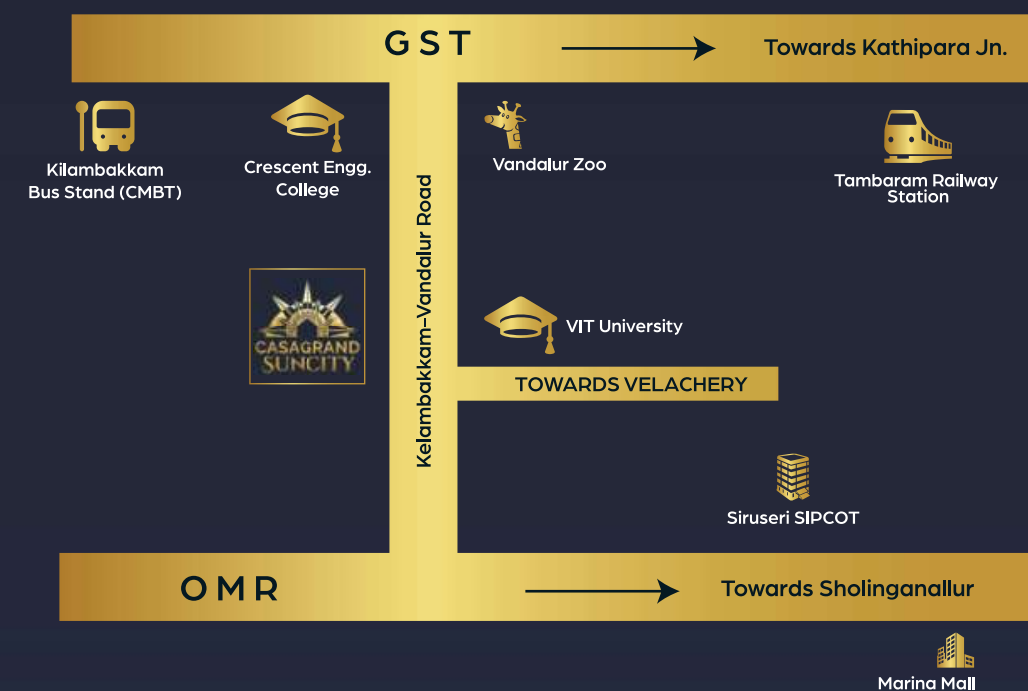
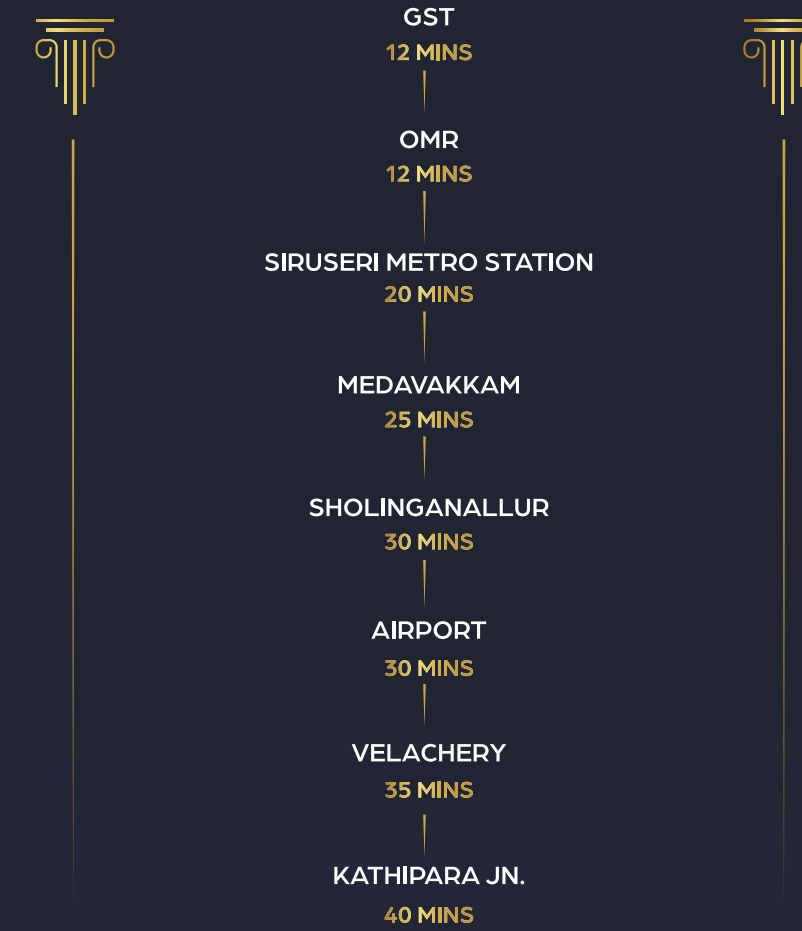
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37. POOL DECK
38. POOLSIDE FRESCO DINING
39. LED SPLASH PAD
40. POOLSIDE LOUNGE
41. REFRESHMENT CORNER
42. DEDICATED KIDS POOL
43. POOLSIDE BASKETBALL HOOP
44. CABANA DECK
45. HYDRAULIC WATER MASSAGE BED
46. JACUZZI / HYDROTHERAPY
47. POOLSIDE THEATER
48. ISLAND SEATING AREA IN THE POOL
49. RAIN CURTAIN
50. CHANGING ROOMS (M/F)
51. SHOWER ROOMS (M/F)
52. OUTDOOR RAIN SHOWER

53. POOLSIDE FRESCO DINING
54. POOLDECK
55. REFRESHMENT CORNER
WITH BBQ
56. KIDS POOL
57. HYDRAULIC WATER MASSAGE BED
58. JACUZZI
59. CHANGING ROOMS (M/F)
60. SHOWER ROOMS (M/F)
61. OUTDOOR RAIN SHOWER

62. POOLSIDE PLAZA WITH DINING & BBQ
63. POOL DECK
64. KIDS POOL
65. GAZEBO
66. POOLSIDE SEATER COURT
67. SHALLOW POOL LOUNGE
68. SCULPTURE COURT
69. CAMPFIRE WITH SEATER
70. LED SPLASH PAD
71. CHANGING ROOMS (M/F)
72. SHOWER ROOMS (M/F)
73. OUTDOOR RAIN SHOWER

74. MULTIPURPOSE LAWN
75. CENTRAL BASILICA
76. CAMPFIRE WITH SWING
77. BUS AND SHUTTLE ARRIVAL
78. STATUE OF HERCULES
79. ENTRANCE PLAZA
80. AIR PAVILION
81. PET PARK
82. IMPERIAL AVENUE
83. TROPICAL FOREST WITH
ELEVATED WALKWAY
84. LABYRINTH GARDEN
85. APOLLO GARDEN
86. SOUL GARDEN
87. LEISURE PAVILION
88. TETHY'S PAVILION
89. TETHY'S PICNIC
90. GRASS MOUND WITH HAMMOCK
91. HERBS & SPICES GARDEN
92. HYACINTH GARDEN

93. ROMAN BRIDGE
94. LUSH GREEN WALL
95. AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO
STATUE MOUND
96. ROLLING MOUND
97. PICNIC CORNER
98. SHALLOW POND WITH ISLAND
99. AQUILEIA PARK
100. GIANT TRAMPOLINE
101. GARDEN SEATING PATIO
102. CORINTH CANAL
103. SPORTS GALLERY
104. CITRUS PLAZA
105. PALM MOUND PATIO
106. OUTDOOR SEATING LAWN
107. AQUA RETREAT
108. AQUA SYMPHONY
109. DELTA FOREST
110. FOUNTAIN OF WEALTH
111. OUTDOOR RAINSHOWER PLAZA

- 112. MINI THEATRE
- 113. MULTIPURPOSE HALL WITH PREFUNCTION LOUNGE
- 114. STEAM, SAUNA, JACUZZI
- 115. UNISEX SALON AND SPA
- 116. SKY CINEMAS
- 117. LEARNING CENTRE
- 118. BUSINESS CENTRE
- 119. CONFERENCE ROOM
- 120. ENTERTAINMENT LOUNGE
- 121. PARTY TERRACE & OUTDOOR DINING
- 122. GUEST BEDROOMS
- 123. PRIVATE TERRACE FOR GUESTS

124. ARCADE ROOM
125. BILLIARDS
126. BOARD GAMES
127. TABLE TENNIS
128. HOCKEY RING TOSS
129. AIR HOCKEY
130. DART BOARD
131. FOOSBALL

132. SQUASH COURT
133. BADMINTON COURT
134. CRICKET SIMULATOR
135. ZUMBA / AEROBICS/ YOGA
136. INTERACTIVE GYM
137. GYM

138. CRECHE
139. KIDS LIBRARY
140. CONFINED KIDS PLAZA
141. KIDS ROCK CLIMBING WALL
WITH BALL PIT
142. TODDLER PLAY AREA
143. DIY TOY TRACK
144. INDOOR TREE PLAZA
145. LEGO WALL
146. KIDS CAMP IN
147. RC RACING TRACK
148. STORY NOOK
149. INTERACTIVE CYCLE RIDER

- 150. INDOOR SWIMMING POOL
- 151. SQUASH COURTS
- 152. BADMINTON COURTS
- 153. CRICKET SIMULATOR
- 154. ZUMBA / AEROBICS/ YOGA
- 155. INTERACTIVE GYM
- 156. TRX TRAINING AREA
- 157. GYM

- 158. MINI THEATRE
- 159. MULTIPURPOSE HALL
- 160. PRE-FUNCTION LOUNGE
- 161. JACUZZI, STEAM & MASSAGE ROOMS
- 162. UNISEX SALON AND SPA
- 163. LEARNING CENTRE
- 164. BUSINESS CENTRE
- 165. CONFERENCE ROOM
- 166. GUEST BEDROOMS

167. ARCADE GAMES
168. BILLIARDS
169. BOARD GAMES ROOM (CHESS, CARROM, FOOSBALL & AIR HOCKEY)
170. TABLE TENNIS
171. VIDEO GAMES ROOM (GAMING CUBICALS, PC GAMES)
172. DART BOARD WALL

- 173. CRECHE
- 174. BOOK GALLERY
- 175. SOFT PLAY AREA
- 176. MINI BOWLING
- 177. CARETAKER DESK
- 178. KIDS LEARNING / ACTIVITY ZONE
- 179. KIDS ROCK CLIMBING WALL
- 180. BALL POOL
- 181. TOY TRACK
- 182. INDOOR TREE PLAZA
- 183. DREAM CORNER
- 184. KIDS PLAY BED
- 185. RECESSED WORKSPACE
- 186. KIDS ROLE PLAY AREA
- 187. KIDS TOILET

- 188. BICYCLE RACK
- 189. CAR WASH BAY
- 190. CAR CHARGING BAY
- 191. ATM
- 192. ASSOCIATION ROOM
- 193. CAFETERIA
- 194. FMS ROOM
- 195. CONVENIO STORE
- 196. PANTRY & KITCHEN
- 197. STORAGE ROOM
- 198. CLINIC

SCAN TO EXPERIENCE
VIRTUAL WALKTHROUGH

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No.1
Ranked in Chennai
for last 8 years*

Top 2
Ranked in
South India

Top 7
Ranked in
India

22+ years
of Trust &
Legacy

7000+
Homes sold in
FY'24 - 25

6 Cities

Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad
Pune, Coimbatore & Dubai

2 months
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Guaranteed resale

7 years
Warranty

10 years
Maintenance by us

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Quality checks

On-time
Delivery of projects

*T&C APPLY

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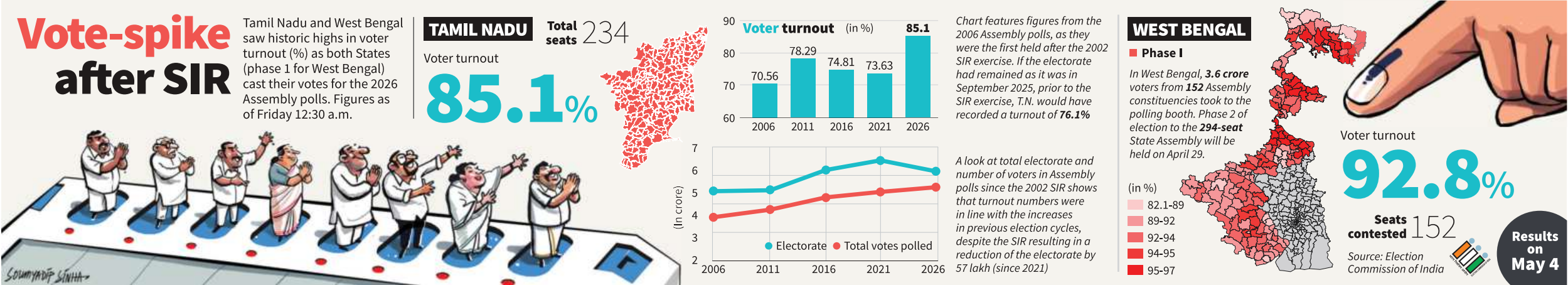
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*Based on CBRE report 2024

CasaGrand Premier Builder Limited is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its equity shares and has filed a draft red herring prospectus ("DRHP") with the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"). The DRHP is available on the website of our Company, at www.casagrand.co.in, the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the websites of the book running lead managers Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited and DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswalgroup.com and www.damcapital.in, respectively, and the websites of the stock exchange(s) at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com, respectively. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" of the RHP, when available. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI for making any investment decision.

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T.N., Bengal see massive turnout

Over 85% polling in Tamil Nadu, highest in its electoral history

Dennis S. Jesudasan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu made electoral history on Thursday as it recorded its highest polling percentage in an Assembly election – 85.1%. According to provisional figures, over 4.85 crore people voted from 7 a.m. in all the 234 Assembly constituencies to elect the 17th Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly. Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar said that it was the highest percentage of polling in the State. “[The] ECI salutes each voter,” he said.

The data released were “provisional and did not include services voters and postal ballots”, a senior official said, meaning that polling figures could still go up.

Tamil Nadu is facing a four-cornered electoral fight involving the ruling DMK-led alliance, the Opposition AIADMK-led alliance, new entrant, actor C. Joseph Vijay-led TVK and the Naam Tamilar Katchi founded by Seeman.

The special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls in the State was strongly cited by SIR critics as the primary reason for the high polling percentage.

The turnout could have been higher if not for the massive traffic snarls of



Digital drive: A robot welcomes voters at a polling booth at Nellikuppam in Cuddalore district of Tamil Nadu on Thursday. S.S. KUMAR

south-bound public and private vehicles from Chennai along the Grand Southern Trunk Road for several hours on Wednesday night.

Poll reflections

Throughout the day, the mood of the electorate was reflected in the shades of the voters' attire, social media posts, and the unsuspecting *kolams*. The choice of the political party and candidate at the ballot was the dominant topic of discussion in almost all public places. Within two hours of polling since 7 a.m., about 17.69% of the electorate had voted and the percentage touched 37.56% by 11 a.m. Even in

Polling peaceful in State barring stray instances of boycott with black flags and scuffles

the scorching heat, the pace of polling seemed to have continued between 11 a.m. and 1 p.m. and the percentage was 56.81% by 1 p.m. After lunch time, the pace dipped and by 3 p.m., the polling percentage was 70%. The turnout crossed 80% by 5 p.m. and stood at 82.24% with about an hour of polling left.

Polling was largely peaceful but for incidents, including in Vengaiyaval where people boycotted

the polls with black flags over caste-based atrocities committed against the Scheduled Castes in 2022.

In Chennai, there were scuffles in Harbour, and Thousand Lights constituencies between supporters of the AIADMK and the DMK.

DMK president and incumbent Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, along with his family members, voted in the Mylapore constituency and AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami voted in the Edappadi constituency. Mr. Vijay and Mr. Seeman voted in Neelankarai.

MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGES 2-7 & 11

Record 93% polling as 152 Bengal constituencies vote in first phase

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal registered a record voter turnout of 92.88% in the first phase of Assembly election on Thursday, amidst isolated incidents of violence. The election, which saw the highest-ever polling in the State, is being held amid a four-month-long special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls that saw a drop in the electorate by about 12%.

Among the districts, Cooch Behar led the State with 96.04% polling, followed by Dakshin Dinajpur at 95.44% and Jalpaiguri at 94.65%. Murshidabad, which recorded the highest number of deletion of electors during the adjudication phase, recorded a voter turnout of 93.61%. According to Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal, the polling percentage is expected to rise further when final figures arrive.

Before the 2026 election, the highest turnout was recorded in 2011 when 84.33% voters exercised their franchise.

The election in 2011 saw the Trinamool Congress defeating the 34-year Left Front government.

The first phase of voting



Mandate on hand: People stand in a queue to cast their vote at Nandigram in West Bengal during the first phase of polls on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

for the 2026 Assembly election was held across 152 Assembly seats and with the polling concluding by 6 p.m., the fate of 1,478 candidates has been sealed in the electronic voting machines (EVMs).

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said that the people came out in large numbers because this was an election to save their right to vote.

“The people know that if they do not vote for the Trinamool Congress, their right to vote will be taken away. The next step is NRC (National Register of Citizens) and they (the Union government) had already brought the delimitation Bill,” Ms. Banerjee said

People came out in large numbers to save their right to vote, says Chief Minister Mamata

while addressing a gathering in Bowbazar area of Kolkata.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who addressed public meetings at three different venues and held a roadshow in the State, congratulated the Election Commission (EC) for holding the polls without much violence.

“I congratulate all the voters. Everyone should celebrate the festival of democracy. There has been

less violence this time so far. I congratulate the Election Commission,” the Prime Minister said, expressing hope that all records will be broken this time with the enthusiasm shown by the people.

Congress leader and Berhampur candidate Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury also expressed satisfaction over the role of the EC.

The EC has deployed over 2,400 companies of Central forces to ensure free and fair elections. Despite the deployment, stray incidents of unrest and violence were reported across different districts.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

NEARBY

High voter turnout in North Chennai

CHENNAI
Assembly constituencies in North Chennai registered a high turnout in the Assembly polls Thursday, with Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar recording 90.5%, the highest among the 16 constituencies of Chennai district. » PAGE 5



Tribal people in ATR brave odds to cast their votes

VALPARAI
A challenging terrain and lack of transport did not deter voters from tribal settlements in the Anamalai Tiger Reserve (ATR) from exercising their franchise. Residents reached the booths on foot and in vehicles arranged by the Forest Department. » PAGE 4

SC questions ED's claim of rule of law breach in Bengal

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked whether the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) was making a case of “breakdown of constitutional machinery” in West Bengal, momentarily pausing the Central agency's rejoinder against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, senior State police officers, and bureaucrats for allegedly violating the rule of law to “barge” into the I-PAC premises in Kolkata during a raid and leaving with material said to be incriminating in a coal smuggling case.

“We hope you are not arguing ‘breakdown of constitutional machinery’ in the context of the controversy you are raising,” Justice N.V. Anjaria, a member of the Division Bench headed by Justice Prashant Kumar Mishra, asked Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the ED.

The failure of constitutional machinery is a ground to impose President's Rule in a State un-



der Article 356 of the Constitution. The query from the Bench followed submissions from the ED about a “well-established pattern” of violations by the Chief Minister, the State police, and the ruling Trinamool Congress, and a “non-existent” rule of law over the years in West Bengal.

Incidents recalled

Mr. Mehta referred to the police “siege” of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) Joint Director's residence in Kolkata and the arrest of CBI officials in 2019, a “mob” of lawyers and party workers crowding into a Calcutta High Court courtroom on January 9, 2026, and the Director-General of Police “act-

ing as the PSO (personal security officer) of the Chief Minister”.

Mr. Mehta responded that there was “nothing up the sleeve” of the ED in the case. He said the “rule of law” was a “part and parcel”, an essential part of Article 14, of the Constitution. The ED officials, against whom the State police registered criminal cases for conducting what was described as a lawful investigation, have a fundamental right to equality before the law or equal protection of the laws. “The ED cannot argue ‘breakdown of constitutional machinery’ [Article 356],” Mr. Mehta said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Pooram scaled down after Thrissur tragedy

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

In the wake of the fireworks tragedy at Mundathikode in Thrissur that killed at least 15, authorities decided on Thursday to conduct this year's Thrissur Pooram without fireworks, while significantly scaling down the *Kudamattam* (parasol exchange), one of its most iconic elements.

The decision was taken at a high-level meeting held at the District Collector's office, attended by State Ministers, Union Minister Suresh Gopi, MPs, elected representatives, and Devaswom officials.

The festival will be conducted largely in a ritualistic format, with reduced visual extravagance.

Devaswoms also informed the meeting that all preparations for the festival had already been completed, making any last-minute withdrawal impractical.

Though the Paramakkavu Devaswom had earlier sought permission to conduct fireworks, govern-



Authorities have decided to hold the annual festival without fireworks this year. FILE PHOTO

ment representatives said legal and technical constraints made it impossible under the present circumstances.

Officials emphasised that the decisions reflect a balance between preserving tradition and responding responsibly to the recent tragedy, noting that the victims of the blast remain central to all considerations.

While all major rituals will be retained, the famed *Kudamattam* will be curtailed to just 15 minutes, with just 10 sets of umbrellas to be displayed.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10



CM
YK



UDHAYANIDHI STALIN



TAMILISAI SOUNDARARAJAN



THOL. THIRUMAVALAVAN



T.T.V. DHINAKARAN



ANBUMANI RAMADOSS

INBRIEF



Sri Lankan refugee casts his first vote as Indian citizen

A long-held dream came true for R. Gokuleswaran, 39, a resident of the Sri Lankan Tamils Rehabilitation Camp at Kottapattu in Tiruchi, when he cast his vote for the first time as an Indian citizen in the Tamil Nadu Assembly election on Thursday. “Most first-time voters are in their early 20s. I am almost 40. But I feel as if my life as an Indian has just begun, and the future of my children as Indian citizens is assured,” Mr. Gokuleswaran, a father of two, who works at a store in Kattur, told *The Hindu* on Thursday. Mr. Gokuleswaran was born on February 9, 1986, in Tiruchi, where he also studied. He was granted citizenship as the year of his birth fell between January 26, 1950, and July 1, 1987, a period that made those born in India eligible for automatic naturalisation as Indians. “Getting my voter ID has given me hope that, if not me, at least my children will be eligible to apply for government jobs when they grow up. There are several Sri Lankan Tamil refugee families who are trying to get their citizenship approved; I hope my journey will encourage others like me,” Mr. Gokuleswaran said.

Head Constable attacked at Mayiladuthurai polling booth

A Head Constable on polling duty was injured after being attacked with a screwdriver at a polling booth in the Poompuhar Assembly constituency in Mayiladuthurai district on Thursday. A former serviceman was arrested in connection with the incident. According to the police, the incident occurred at Booth No. 324 at the Jamaliya Aided Elementary School in Porayar. Head Constable G. Vignesh, attached to the Kuthalam police station and deployed on security duty, was allegedly attacked by R. Prabhakaran, a resident of Kattucherry. The accused is said to have stabbed the Head Constable in the neck and hands. The victim was rushed to the Porayar Government Hospital, where he was given first aid and sutures. His condition is said to be stable. Police sources said the accused was mentally unstable, and allegedly harboured resentment towards police personnel. He had also been involved in a similar assault on a police officer a few years ago, sources added.

T.N. may see close contests in many constituencies

The presence of TVK founder Vijay is said to have turned the contest into a three-cornered one instead of the usual bipolar race, paving the way for closer electoral battles than in the past

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

With the State witnessing a perceptibly high turnout in percentage terms, the focus turns to the margin of victory that winners record over their immediate rivals in general.

Even in the run-up to the day of polling, the presence of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) founder C. Joseph Vijay had generated the talk that the contest had become a three-cornered one instead of the usual bipolar race, thereby paving the way for closer electoral battles than in the past.

A look at the margins of difference between the winners and the runners-up in the three Assembly elections since the 2008 delimitation reveals that the closest contest was witnessed in 2016, as the difference between the ruling AIADMK and the DMK-led coalition was

Scale of success

A comparison of the victory margins in the past three elections

Margin	2011	2016	2021
< 1,000 votes	9	16	8
1,001 to 5,000 votes	17	37	31
5,001 to 10,000 votes	27	44	30
10,001 to 20,000 votes	58	74	51
20,001 to 50,000 votes	110	60	89
> 50,000 votes	13	3	25



Taking their pick: People queuing up to vote at a polling station in Chennai on Thursday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

about one percentage point. This was followed by the gap of a little more than five percentage points in 2021 between the two formations led by the DMK and the AIADMK. In 2021, the double digit percentage-point difference went in favour of the AIADMK-led coalition.

It was against this back-

drop that the margin was up to 5,000 votes only in 26 seats in the 2011 election. Five years later, the tally went up to 53, and in 2021, it was 39.

Multi-cornered fight

The primary reason for the 2016 poll registering such a margin in 50-odd constituencies was the

The closest contest in the three Assembly elections since the 2008 delimitation was witnessed in the 2016 poll

multi-cornered fight.

Apart from the traditional Dravidian adversaries, the People's Welfare Front (Makkal Nala Kootani), the Pattali Makkal Katchi, and the Bharatiya Janata Party contested alone. In 2021, most of them were on the side of either of the principal forces. The same holds good even now.

Talking of the present situation, a veteran leader in the DMK concedes that this time, the margin may be narrow in many places, as witnessed in 2016. Echoing this opinion, a functionary of the AIADMK feels that in such an eventuality, the Vijay factor is likely to be one of the causes for the anticipated close contest.



I have done my democratic duty. The people of Tamil Nadu should also do so. What you are casting is not a vote. It is a shield you wield to protect Tamil Nadu. Your vote will determine the future of each individual in Tamil Nadu

M.K. STALIN
Tamil Nadu Chief Minister



J. JOHAN SATHYAN



All voters must go to the polling booths and perform their democratic duty

EDAPPADI K. PALANISWAMI, AIADMK general secretary



VIP voter: Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam leader C. Joseph Vijay casting his vote at a polling booth in Neelankarai in Chennai. PTI



Decision time: NTK leader Seeman casting his vote at a polling station in Neelankarai in Chennai.

Arduous trek to polling booth for Anamalai's tribal folk

Wilson Thomas
VALPARAI

A challenging terrain and lack of transport failed to prevent voters from tribal settlements in the Anamalai Tiger Reserve (ATR) from exercising their franchise in the Valparai (R) constituency on Thursday.

Members of the Pulaiyar community from the Keel Poonachi tribal settlement cast their votes at Attakatti on Valparai-Pollachi Road.

Of the 286 voters listed in the booth, most are tribal people from Keel Poonachi and Upper Aliyar, and staff from the electricity board quarters. These people depend on a TNSCT bus that plies occasionally between Pollachi and Kadamparai, where a hydroelectric power house is located, to reach the outside world.

“We need to walk along a mud road in the jungle to reach the settlement from Marappalam on the Atta-



Tough task: Tribal women walking through the Anamalai Tiger Reserve to reach the polling booth near Attakatti. WILSON THOMAS

katti-Kadamparai Road. When there is no bus, we walk,” said R. Kanagaraj, a Pulaiyar tribesman from

Keel Poonachi. A. Arumugam, a tribal leader of Keel Poonachi, said voters from the 50-odd families in the

settlement turned up to vote. While Mr. Arumugam and a few others managed to board the bus plying between Karamparai and Pollachi to get down at Attakatti, a group of women missed it. They walked through the forest to reach Attakatti.

V. Narayanan, a Muthuvar tribesman from Vellimudi, said he felt proud after exercising his franchise. He voted with his wife N. Kanthayi and

their relative D. Devagani at the Kadamparai booth.

“Vehicles were arranged for tribal voters to reach the booth. Awareness activities had been conducted in advance, which resulted in a better turnout,” Zonal Officer S. Kanimuthu told *The Hindu* at Kadamparai.

Residents of several other tribal settlements reached the booths on foot and in vehicles arranged by the Forest Department.

A majority of Vengaiyaval's SC residents boycott election over 2022 water contamination case

Nacchinarkkiniyan M.
PUDUKKOTTAI

A majority of the residents of Vengaiyaval, a Scheduled Caste hamlet in Pudukkottai district, boycotted the election on Thursday, alleging that members of their community had been falsely implicated in the 2022 incident in which human faeces were found in an overhead drinking water tank. Only eight of the 69 residents cast their votes.

Black flags were hoisted across the village. The residents reiterated their demand for action against the “real culprits”. They maintained that the CB-CID, which probed the case, had wrongly named residents of the hamlet as the accused.

“They are framing us in a case where we are the victims. In the last Lok Sabha election, when officials tried to persuade us to vote, we were promised that the real culprits would be arrested, and our infrastructure and livelihood needs would be ad-



Sending a message: Black flags were hoisted across Vengaiyaval, including near the overhead water tank that was at the centre of the contamination incident in 2022. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



They [the CB-CID] are framing us in a case where we are the victims

K.R. MURUGAN
A resident

dressed. None of the promises have been kept. So, we are determined not to vote,” said K.R. Murugan, a resident.

Polling, however, was peaceful in the neighbouring Eraiyur, where the residents withdrew their election boycott call after talks with officials.

Vengaiyaval and Eraiyur. Following an inquiry, the CB-CID registered a case against some residents of Vengaiyaval, drawing strong opposition from the hamlet.

In the run-up to the election, the residents of both villages announced a poll boycott. They installed banners listing their demands, including the arrest of the “real culprits” in the contamination case. Eraiyur residents also sought the withdrawal of cases filed under the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act against them; restoration of a government bus service between Pudukkottai and Kaveri Nagar through Eraiyur; and improved civic amenities.

The villages had called for a boycott of the 2024 Lok Sabha election. However, after negotiations, the Vengaiyaval residents took part in the voting, while the Eraiyur residents abstained. This time, the Eraiyur residents voted,

while the Vengaiyaval residents boycotted the election.

Another boycott

Residents of Perumpaththu near Nanguneri in Tirunelveli district also boycotted the election. Only five of the 969 voters exercised their franchise.

A Scheduled Caste resident of Indra Colony at Perumpaththu and a migrant labourer from Odisha were killed on the spot when a gang attacked a group of people near a tea shop in February. The gang also hacked four others in the area, and a person in a nearby village.

The attack left Nelson, one of the victims, crippled. The families of the victims appealed to the government for compensation and government jobs. As no assurance was given, the villagers decided to boycott the election. Till 11 a.m., no one turned up to vote. After persuasion and assurances by officials and the candidates for the Nanguneri constituency, only five voters cast their votes.

Stampede remains etched in Velusampuram's memory

C. Jaisankar
KARUR

Velusampuram, located on the outskirts of Karur, where 41 people were killed in a stampede during a rally addressed by TVK president C. Joseph Vijay on September 27, 2025, witnessed brisk polling on Thursday.

However, the tragedy that shocked the conscience of the nation fails to fade away from the memories of the voters. What was meant to be a show of strength for Mr. Vijay turned into one of the country's deadliest political tragedies. Many questions remain unanswered.

V. Vimal, 26, who lost his 18-month-old son, Guru Vishnu, is yet to come to terms with the tragedy. He did not want to vote till Thursday morning. However, paying heed to the persistent requests of his friends, he cast his vote at the Panchayat Union Middle School at Velusampuram.

“Almost seven months have passed since the tra-



Still scarred: A view of Velusampuram on the day of polling for the Assembly election on Thursday. R. VENGADESH

gedy occurred. But the truth has not yet emerged. I do not want to point the finger at anyone, as I am eagerly waiting for the outcome of the investigation. I would have happily voted, had the CBI cracked the case,” says Mr. Vimal.

By around 2 p.m. on Thursday, booth number 15 at the Panchayat Union Middle School, located a few yards from the site of the stampede, registered 81.31% polling.

Of the 637 electors, 518 cast their votes, with nearly four hours left for the closure of polling, indicating that the tragedy has in no way curbed the enthu-

siasm of the voters. Velusampuram is part of the Karur constituency, where TVK candidate V.P. Mathiazhagan, one of the accused in the stampede case, is taking on M. Thiyagarajan of the DMK, and former Minister M.R. Vijayabhaskar of the AIADMK.

“It [the stampede] should not have happened. The blame game was on for quite some time. But we are not sure about the reasons for the stampede, and who are responsible for it. Hence, I thought it should not influence how I vote,” says A. Sudhakar, 28, another resident.



VAIKO



P. SHANMUGAM



O. PANNEERSELVAM



PREMALLATHA VIJAYAKANT



R. PRIYA

INBRIEF



M. MOORTHY

Model booths impress voters across age groups in Tiruchi

Model booths set up in Tiruchi for the Assembly elections received a good response from voters, especially senior citizens and persons with disabilities, on Thursday. The model booth at the Seva Sangam Girls' Higher Secondary School was equipped with facilities such as cloth canopies to shield voters from the sharp sunshine, and had wheelchairs and accessibility ramps. Persons with disabilities and senior citizens were allowed to enter the booth on priority to ensure that they were able to vote comfortably.

People of T.N. were waiting for this day, says Anbumani

PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss cast his vote, along with his daughters, at a polling booth in T. Nagar in Chennai on Thursday. Dr. Anbumani, whose party is fighting this election as part of the National Democratic Alliance, said: "It is a day on which women, mothers, farmers, drug addicted-youngsters, unemployed youngsters, government employees, workers, and traders are going to get their freedom. People of Tamil Nadu were waiting for this day over the last five years." PMK Dharmapuri candidate and Dr. Anbumani's wife, Sowmiya Anbumani, also cast her vote later in the afternoon. TNCC president K. Selvaparthigai cast his vote, along with his wife and daughter, at Manimangalam in Sriperumbudur constituency.

Choked highways, bus service disruptions give voters a tough time on day of polling

GST Road was one of the worst affected stretches as vehicles moved at a snail's pace on Thursday morning, leaving motorists going to the outskirts for voting anguished. A senior Transport Department official said disruptions were largely reported at the Kilambakkam bus terminus near Chennai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/ERODE/
MADURAI/COIMBATORE

Grand Southern Trunk (GST) Road witnessed heavy traffic congestion between Perungulathur and the Kilambakkam bus terminus in the morning of Thursday, when the Assembly elections was held across the State.

Cars and buses inched forward at a snail's pace, taking almost an hour to cross the stretch, which is barely three to four kilometres long. It left several motorists anguished, as some were heading to the outskirts to cast their votes.

Vettrivel Rajan, an advocate from Tambaram, said he was stuck on the stretch for nearly two hours on his way to vote in Oorapakam. "I was not sure when I would reach or when I could cast my vote. I did not expect this kind of traffic when I started from my residence," he said. However, the jam began clearing after 10 a.m. A section of people said that owing to closure of schools, families that had cast their votes



Clogged stretch: Vehicles lined up on GST Road near Perungalathur on Thursday. SAPTARSHI BHATTACHARYA

early were looking to get away for a short break, contributing to the influx of vehicles.

Sources in the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) said Chennai-Tiruchi National Highway also witnessed heavy traffic on Wednesday night. They said the traffic was heavier than what was witnessed during Deepavali last year. Traffic congestion was also reported at a few places, including near the Chengalpattu Collectorate and town, due to the movement of local vehicles, which were ferrying vo-

ters, and election vehicles. Since vehicles were frequently criss-crossing on the highway, the flow of traffic slowed down considerably.

Travel across Tamil Nadu also saw disruptions on polling day, with many commuters facing delays and difficulty in accessing bus services as they tried to reach their home towns to cast their votes. A senior Transport Department official said disruptions were largely reported at the Kilambakkam bus terminus near Chennai. Heavy traffic congestion on GST Road

on the intervening night between Wednesday and Thursday, caused due to a surge in private vehicles heading to the southern districts, delayed the entry of incoming buses between 1 a.m. and 5 a.m., affecting schedules.

Passengers protest

At the new bus stand at Solar in Erode district, passengers bound for southern districts, such as Madurai and Dindigul, protested, demanding that more buses be operated immediately. Many said they had arrived from

Chennai and other cities early on Thursday morning but were unable to proceed further due to the lack of services. Tension prevailed for some time as commuters raised slogans and argued with the Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation (TNSTC) staff.

Passengers also pointed to operational constraints at the new facility, where only TNSTC buses were being run, while private omni buses continued to function from the Corporation's Central Bus Stand following an interim court order. This, they said, added to the congestion and delays.

In Coimbatore, hundreds of passengers waited for several hours at the Singanallur bus stand on Wednesday night for buses to the southern districts. A section of commuters staged a brief road blockade in front of the bus stand, protesting the shortage of services. Kiran Kumar, a student, said he reached the bus stand at 6 a.m. but managed to board a Dindigul-bound bus only around 7 a.m., after struggling through heavy crowds. Passengers who

reached the Mattuthavani bus stand in Madurai said delays in getting direct buses from cities such as Chennai forced them to rely on connecting services. However, overcrowding at transit points such as Salem and Kallakurichi left many stuck midway.

'Services streamlined'

The senior Transport Department official said services were later streamlined and additional buses were operated. As of Thursday morning, about 6,738 buses had been run across the State, with around 4.4 lakh passengers boarding from Kilambakkam alone. From April 21 to 23, a total of 10,663 buses, including 5,574 special services, were operated from Kilambakkam, Koyambedu, and Madhavaram bus termini.

Officials said more services would be operated through the day and urged passengers to avoid last-minute travel. However, commuters said the arrangements fell short of demand during the peak rush, leading to overcrowding and delays at several bus stands.

TVK and DMK party workers clash at Harbour constituency in Chennai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Party workers, led by TVK candidate Sinora Ashok and DMK candidate and Minister P.K. Sekarbabu, were locked in a skirmish, after the latter reportedly questioned the "suspicious" presence of the former near a booth on Angappa Naicken Street in the Harbour constituency. Claiming that Mr. Sekarbabu had threatened them, the TVK workers resorted to a protest.

As the situation escalated, the police officers intervened and pacified them.

Three persons, including two members of the TVK and a councillor of the DMK, were injured in a clash near the Aranganathan subway in Saidapet on Thursday evening. The in-

jured were identified as Senthamizhan and Ramakrishnan, both lawyers and TVK cadre, and Sridhar, DMK councillor of ward 140. According to the police, the incident occurred when TVK cadre were waiting near the subway. At that time, DMK candidate Ma Subramanian arrived at the location along with Mr. Sridhar. The councillor asked the TVK cadre to vacate the area, which led to a verbal argument between the groups.

The police are investigating after Rathai, a functionary of the TVK, alleged that she was assaulted by DMK members near a polling booth on VM Street in Royapettah, sparking a brief road blockade by her party cadre.

Tension prevailed at a polling station in Otteri af-

ter a woman named Amulu alleged that her vote had already been cast when she arrived to exercise her franchise in the Thiru. Vi. Ka. Nagar Assembly constituency on Thursday. Officials said a detailed inquiry was on.

NTK candidate attacked Anis Fathima, NTK candidate for the Papanasam Assembly Constituency, was admitted to the Government Rajah Mirasdar Hospital in Thanjavur on April 23 as she was allegedly manhandled by polling agents of the DMK and the IUML at a booth in the constituency.

According to NTK sources, Ms. Fathima, who was pregnant, had visited the polling booth at Ukkadai in Ammapettai, when police personnel had directed her

to remove the shawl carrying the party's election symbol.

She had complied with the direction and entered the booth only to find a person, wearing a shirt with the 'Ladder' symbol of the IUML candidate A.M. Shahjahan speaking to polling agents. When she pointed this out to the police personnel who asked her to remove her shawl, they asked her to lodge a complaint in writing. As she was preparing the complaint, IUML and DMK party cadre barged into the booth and pushed Ms. Fathima and started abusing her. Subsequently, NTK sources said they decided to lodge a complaint with the Superintendent of Police as the Ammapettai Police refused to entertain a complaint.

NOTA loses ground as electors in State lean towards new political alternatives

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

None of the Above (NOTA) does not appear to have emerged as a particularly strong choice for voters this time. While a few voters said they did opt for NOTA, there has been little chatter to suggest any broad or significant surge in its support.

R. Shyamala of Ayanavaram said she voted NOTA this time as she did not think any of the parties deserved her vote. "I did not like any of the parties," she said. NOTA was introduced in India in 2013 after a landmark ruling by the Supreme Court. It was first implemented in the Assembly elections held later that year. Nitin of Maduravoyal constituency also chose NOTA this time, say-



NOTA was introduced in India in 2013 after a Supreme Court verdict. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

ing that some areas in the constituency had not seen improvements in infrastructure and there were hardly any changes. However, many people do not see NOTA as an important option. R. Chaitanya, for instance, said she had often chosen NOTA in the past because she did not feel fully informed enough about politics to support a particular party with confidence. "In Tamil Nadu,

politics has largely been either the DMK or the AIADMK for many years, and from my point of view, past elections did not seem to bring much difference in outcomes. Because of that, I felt that my single vote would not make much impact, so I've chosen NOTA before." This time, however, she voted for a particular party.

Tara Krishnaswamy, politics and policy expert, said since NOTA was introduced in 2013, there was a certain degree of enthusiasm in the following years. "People felt that the party they were voting for was suboptimal, and they had grievances," she said. She explained that there was optimism around what NOTA could potentially accomplish. "But NOTA was not implemented in the

way it should have been. It remains largely a signalling mechanism and does not drive electoral outcomes. Over time, people realised this; the percentage of NOTA votes was minuscule, and many came to feel that it was not particularly relevant," she added.

Karthikeyan, whose vote is in Velachery, also said he voted NOTA in the last two elections, but this time had one party in mind to support. "I chose one that has experience working for the people. But I didn't get to vote because my name was deleted after SIR," he said. While NOTA continues to serve as a symbolic avenue for dissent, its practical influence appears limited, and many voters now gravitate towards parties they see as offering tangible change.

Two Scheduled Tribe couples exercise their franchise for the first time this election



Getting their chance: From left, Masi and Govindammal from Konai village in Villupuram district and S. Mahaprabhu and M. Mariyammal from Kottur village in Sriperumbudur district.



Sunitha Sekar
Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

When one thinks of first-time voters, it is usually people aged between 18 and 20. But at Konai village in Villupuram district, a couple aged over 40 and 50 cast their votes for the very first time on Thursday. Masi and Govindammal, who belong to a Scheduled Tribe (ST) community, received their voter IDs only recently and were able to vote for the first time.

"We applied earlier but

never got it," Mr. Masi said. The couple, parents of four daughters, had also been trapped in bonded labour for six years in Vazhapadi, Salem district.

They worked at a brick kiln for a meagre wage of ₹1,000 per week for both of them after borrowing ₹50,000 for their younger daughter's marriage. They recall living in extremely harsh conditions.

"There was no drinking water or proper housing. We had to make 10,000 bricks a week and travel 20 km to buy rice and dal with

our wages," Mr. Masi said.

On March 30, the Special Court for Exclusive Trial of SC/ST (POA) Act Cases, Villupuram, found that the brick kiln owner had exploited the family and held him guilty of forced labour, harassment of a woman, bonded labour offences, and forcing ST members into such labour. He was acquitted of abduction and wrongful confinement charges due to lack of proof but was sentenced to multiple prison terms along with a fine of ₹5,000 on other charges.

After voting on Thursday, Ms. Govindammal said they were very happy to exercise their democratic right for the very first time.

April 23 was a rather unusual day for another couple from Kottur village in Sriperumbudur.

After hearing of elections and seeing people vote these many decades, 62-year-old S. Mahaprabhu and 52-year-old M. Mariyammal had cast their vote for the first time on Thursday.

"I am quite happy. Both

of us always felt bad about missing out on voting," said Ms. Mariyammal, who belongs to the Irula community.

She said they never had a voter ID all these years and did not know how to go about getting one either. She said they currently lived in a hut and requested the government to build a house for them.

Mr. Maharaja said he was also glad to have finally been able to vote.

"My wife and I collect plastic and glass bottles and sell them at a scrap

shop to make a living. It's been very difficult to make ends meet," he added.

Kavitha Thandhoni, president of the Sriperumbudur Irular People Welfare Association, said they conducted a survey among the Irula community at Kottur village sometime ago. "When we find out they don't have any identification proof like Aadhaar, ration card, and voter ID, we initiate the process to get those for them. In January this year, we managed to obtain voter ID for both of them," she added.

Three couples come to vote after their wedding in Tiruvallur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Three newly-married couples in the Ponneri and Gummidipoondi constituencies of Tiruvallur district went to their polling booths to fulfil their democratic duty on Thursday.

The three couples, still dressed up in wedding finery, visited their polling booths to cast their votes. In the Ponneri Assembly constituency of the Tiruvallur district, S. Subash, a software engineer at an information technology company, left for the panchayat middle school at Ariyanvoyal in Minjur to cast his vote, after marrying Ramya of Korukkupet. Emerging from the polling booth, Mr. Subhash



S. Subash and his wife Ramya at the polling station in the panchayat middle school in Ariyanvoyal. M. SRINATH

said he was accompanying his wife to Korukkupet, where she had to vote. Similarly, Monisha and Vishal of Neythavayal village in Minjur, and Bharat-kumar and Gayathri of Elapuram village in Periyapalayam cast their votes after tying the knot.

Play area for children at model polling booth

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

Rumana N. was relieved to find a children's play area at the Anna Nagar Model Polling Booth, where she had gone to vote during the Assembly election on Thursday. As a mother of twins, she was worried about taking care of her children while voting. "I was pleased to see the kids' playing area at the polling centre. I was stressed in the morning, wondering how to manage them," she said.

She was waiting at the

playing area for her parents to complete voting, so that she could cast her vote while her mother kept a watch over the children. The playing area had about eight horses with wheels and a see-saw, the kids were delighted to see it, with many pulling their parents to give it a go.

It was an initiative by the Greater Chennai Corporation, a senior official said, adding that while the idea was floated, it was left to the discretion of the Returning Officer to implement it. This helped parents to plan their voting.

Residents across T.N. upset over SIR-related deletions

A resident says that her family filled out forms and submitted all the required documents, but the names were removed from the list after SIR. They did not get any response from officials, she adds

Sahana Mira S
Serena Josephine M.
CHENNAI

In a sense, the Special Intensive Revision (SIR)-related deletions did cast a shadow over the State elections, leaving several voters unable to exercise their franchise. While many of them followed due processes to include their names before the final roll was published, some of them discovered that their names did not figure in the electoral roll only days before the polling.

While this year, the number of complaints of deletions or bogus voting has come down rather dramatically, in comparison, there were other kinds of peeves from voters who failed to check the voter rolls assuming their names would be present, and arrived at the booth, only to find out that their names were missing. Some of them also complained that they had applied for addition, but that was not done.

According to details gathered through crowdsourcing on 'X' and field-level interactions, a number of persons, even long-time voters, who had valid voter identity cards, found themselves removed from the electoral roll following the SIR exercise.

Prasanna, a voter in Villivakkam constituency, said that both his name and his mother's were de-



Some long-time voters, who had valid voter identity cards, found themselves removed from the electoral roll following SIR. R. RAGU

leted following SIR due to address mismatch. "We previously lived in Mogapair, which came under Maduravoyal constituency. By the time we applied for a change of address, the deadline had passed. If the Election Commission had started the SIR process earlier, it would have given us enough time to update our address and reapply," he said.

Gayathri, 22, a voter in Mylapore constituency, was looking forward to cast her first vote. She made sure to obtain a voter ID well in time. "I got my voter ID a few months before the SIR process began. We filled out the forms and submitted all the required documents. So, we never imagined our votes could be affected. To our surprise, we later found that our names were missing from the electoral roll after the final list was published.

We reached out to several officials, but there was no response," she said.

She added that her parents have been voting for decades, and this is the first time they were unable to vote.

It came as a shock for Dhruv Gangadharan, a resident of Thirumalai Pillai Road in T. Nagar, when he and several of his neighbours realised their names were missing from the electoral roll. "One of our neighbours had coordinated with the election staff to submit all our SIR forms with the required documents," he said.

In another instance, a couple aged 75 and 67 in Avinashi constituency had their names deleted citing 'system technical error, could not feed SIR information on time'. Though they resubmitted in the new window period, nothing had happened. They

have been voting since the 1980s.

Sukanya, who moved from Pattinampakkam to Kannagi Nagar, took a day's leave from work as a domestic help to vote. A voter in the Mylapore constituency, she was unable to find her name on the electoral roll, as she was unaware of the SIR exercise.

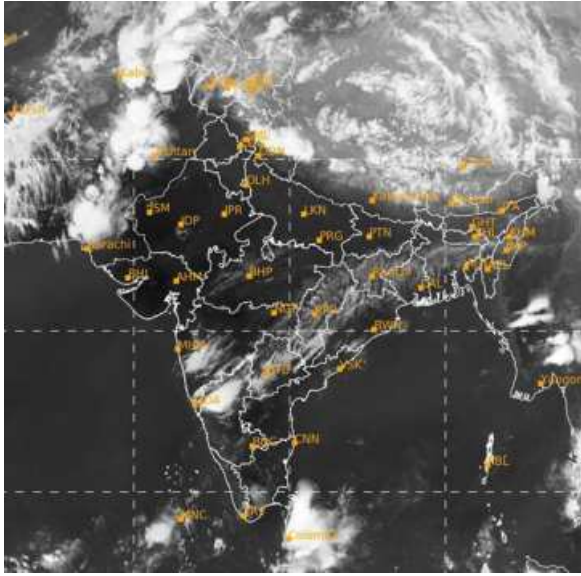
A young chartered accountant and his family at Kesavaperumalpuram were unable to cast their votes even after submitting Form 6 owing to their names being changed to 'permanently shifted' despite the family residing at the same address for the past 30 years.

In Villivakkam constituency, Vijaya Anand had to go back and forth from the polling booth to polling agents' desk since he was able to cast his vote while his wife could not. "We both submitted the Form 6 together but only I received the booth slip at home. The polling agents are saying they are unable to find her slip online," he added.

Vidya Srinivasan, 84, from Damodharapuram, Adyar, had another confusion to tackle. With polling agents in her neighbourhood unable to find her booth slip, they asked her to return home. Ms. Srinivasan had to wait for 30 minutes by the road before a family member eventually located it for her in the electoral rolls.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Friday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Jammu & Kashmir, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya, Sikkim, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		36.4	25.2	Kozhikode		37.6	28.3
Ahmedabad		41.5	25.6	Kurnool		43.1	28.5
Aizawl		32.6	18.8	Lucknow		42.2	25.3
Allahabad		44.4	23.6	Madurai		40.0	26.5
Bengaluru		36.4	22.9	Mangaluru		33.8	26.0
Bhopal		41.0	22.6	Mumbai		35.9	24.4
Bhubaneswar		42.1	26.4	Mysuru		37.2	23.0
Chandigarh		40.0	20.9	New Delhi		41.7	25.4
Chennai		37.5	27.2	Patna		41.3	27.4
Coimbatore		38.5	25.0	Port Blair		33.3	26.6
Dehradun		37.5	20.2	Puducherry		35.0	26.5
Gangtok		24.1	14.2	Pune		41.8	26.0
Goa		35.3	26.5	Raipur		42.8	27.0
Guwahati		32.2	21.5	Ranchi		38.9	23.0
Hubballi		37.0	24.0	Shillong		24.8	13.0
Hyderabad		39.7	28.5	Shimla		30.2	19.5
Imphal		29.5	17.5	Srinagar		27.8	12.2
Jaipur		39.6	26.4	Thiruvananthapuram		35.5	26.7
Kochi		38.4	28.2	Tiruchi		38.5	26.6
Kohima		27.0	16.0	Vijayawada		39.5	26.4
Kolkata		38.7	27.6	Visakhapatnam		31.7	28.6

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		48	147	10		48	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Angul, Odisha
Bengaluru		9	12	32		144	recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of
Chennai		15	6	47		17	286 indicating an unhealthy level of
Delhi		37	109	44		165	pollution. In contrast,
Hyderabad		16	16	38		63	Naharlagun, Arunachal Pradesh recorded a
Kolkata		8	36	39		60	healthy AQI score of 23
Lucknow		10	56	46		250	
Mumbai		3	21	37		60	
Pune		37	58	61		58	
Visakhapatnam		28	64	25		27	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

BATTERY OPERATED FORKLIFT
E-Tender No. NB265330 Dated: 21-04-2026. E-Tenders are invited by the undersigned for the following works:-
Name of work: Battery operated FORKLIFT, 03 ton capacity, specification as per Attached Annexure. Make/Brand: Goorej, Ace Or Equivalent. **Earnest Money:** ₹60,420/-. **Date & time of closing tender:** at 14.30 hrs. on 11-05-2026. The complete information with tender documents of above e-Tender will be available in www.ireps.gov.in
Dy. CMMD/New Bongaigaon
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

South East Central Railway Tender Notice
Srl. No. (1) Tender No: TRS-BSP-2026-27-OT-04, Date: 16/04/2026.
Work: Cleaning, Stripping / dismantling / Uncoupling of Electrical components of Electric locomotive at ELS/BSP. **Tender Value:** ₹ 1,37,99,513.91/- **EMD:** ₹2,76,000/- **Submission of Tender:** upto 11:00 hrs. on dtd 07.05.2026.
For further details, eligibility criteria & the complete details for the above work, please contact Office of the **Sr.DEE(TRS/BSP, S.E.C. Railway** or refer/download tender document which is available on our website: www.ireps.gov.in
Divt. Elect Engineer (TRS) S.E.C. Railway, Bilaspur
South East Central Railway @social

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
Salem Division
Office of the Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer Electric Loco Shed, Erode
E-Tender Notice
Online tender is invited for the following work:
Tender No SA_A_RS_ED_OT_26_27_2, Dated: 21-04-2026
Description of Work Servicing of ELGI make TRC1000 MN, TRC1000 MNUG, compressors of electric locomotives available at Electric Loco Shed, Southern Railway, Salem Division, Erode.
All details regarding the tender are available at <https://www.ireps.gov.in>
DEE/RS/ED For Sr.DEE/RS/ED

Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation
Central Offices, Purchase Department, Shanthinagar, Bangalore - 560027. PH: (091)-080-22221321(E:224) FAX:(091)-080-22223424, "e-mail: cosp@Ksrtc.org" Website: www.ksrtc.org
No. KST/CO/S&P/SSD/96/2026-27 Date: 22.04.2026
"e"-Auction Notice
Scrap Materials available at our 16 Divisions & Regional Workshops, Kengeri/Hassan of KSRTC will be sold through e-Auction to be conducted by M/s. Rashtriya e Markets Services Pvt.Ltd (ReMSL) (A State Government Undertaking).
The e-Auction schedule is as under:-
Scrap material e-Auction Start from **28.04.2026**
The interested Bidders may log onto www.scrapauctions.neml.in for further details and registration. They may also contact M/s. ReMSL at below mentioned address for needful clarification.
Address:-
M/s Rashtriya e Markets Services Pvt. Ltd Karnataka State Agricultural Marketing Board,
No. 16, Rajbhavan road, Bangalore- 560 001.
Contact phone Nos: 8970314455, 7625015646, 9742492299, 9742079246
KSRTC Contact phone Nos: +91 7760990221/224
Sd/-
DIPR/CP/329/Zen/2026-27
CONTROLLER OF STORES & PURCHASES

MAHATRANSCO
Mahatransco Limited
INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) (LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)
SRM e-Tender No. T-2615/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001493) (1st Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
"Creation of 400/220 kV Switchyard at M/s GWEL for evacuation arrangement for MSEDCL share of 200 MW power from 2x300 MW Thermal Power Plant Dist. Chandrapur under Nagpur zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra."
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website <https://srmnetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from 21.04.2026.
Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
(Construction Organisation)
E-Tender Notice No. ERS-SG-CN-2026-OT-02
Double Packet System
For and on behalf of The President of India, **The Dy. Chief Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, Construction, Southern Railway, Ernakulam**, II Floor, Eastern Entry, Ernakulam Junction, Karshaka Road, Kochi-682 012 invites **e-tenders** for the following work.

Item.No.	Name of the work			
1.	Provision of indoor and outdoor Signalling and Telecommunication arrangements at Neyyattinkara station for Stage-I & Stage-II works in connection with doubling of Track between Thiruvananthapuram Central & Kanniyakumari stations.			
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Sl.No.	Approximate Cost of Work (₹)	Bid security (₹)	Last Date of e-submission of Tender/Date of Opening of the Tender	Period of Completion (Months)
1.	24,11,79,681.85	48,23,600/-	12/05/2026 15:00 hrs	8 (Eight) months

Note:1. Value of tender inclusive of GST as per GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time for the supply and services by the tenderer.
2. Visit www.ireps.gov.in for detailed terms and conditions and corrigendum if any.
Deputy Chief Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, Construction, Southern Railway, Ernakulam-682 016

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice
DRM/Electrical, North Western Railway, Jodhpur for & on behalf of the president of India, invites e-tender for the following work. 1. Complete details of tenders can be seen on Website No.: <http://www.ireps.gov.in>, 2.Date & time of closing of e-tender:-13.05.2026 up to 15.00 hrs., 3. Date & time of opening of e-tender:- After 15.00 hrs. on 13.05.2026, **Tender No.:** 39R1/2025-26. **Name of Work:** (i) Electrical work in connection with provision of new high level platform 4/5 at Barmer Station with 04 bay platform shelter, water booths, benches, extension of existing foot over bridge from PF-2/3 to the new PF-4/5 (ii) Electrical work in connection with provision of raising of PF-2 from medium level to high level with 03 seater benches water booths at Marwar Kori, Malwara and Kavas (03) stations in the section of Sr.DEN/ West, **Approx. Cost of the work (Rs.):** Rs. 10550722.64, **Tender No.:** 48R/2025-26, **Name of Work:** Electrical work in connection (i) construction of community hall at Bhagat ki Kothi over Jodhpur Division (ii) Electrical work in connection construction of community hall including sports facilities at Merta Road, Degana over Jodhpur Division. (iii) Electrical work in connection with provision of 05 bed barrack for RPF Staff at out post Luni, (iv)-Electrical work in connection with provision of 20 bedded officer and staff barrack at RPF line Jodhpur including Canteen, armoury, store, toilets etc (v) Electrical work in connection with provision of Additional 10 bed Barrack for RPF staff at Merta Road. (vi) Electrical work in connection with provision of 10 bedded barrack at Nagaur Station (vii)-Proposed out post building with 10 bedded barrack at Nagaur Station (viii)-Proposed out post building with 10 bedded barrack at DEGANA STATION (ix) Improvement of community halls Officer club at Jodhpur under ADEN/HQ/JU Jurisdiction, **Approx. Cost of the work (Rs.):** Rs. 8385568.43, **Tender No.:** GSUELECTG-10 /2025-26, **Name of Work:** Electrical work in connection with (a) provision of new FOB at Jalsu, Gachhipura, Marwar Lohawat, Deshnok stations. (b) Provision of customer facilities at Goods shed of Kairla Station., **Approx. Cost of the work (Rs.):** Rs 8713774.59. For detailed information visit: <http://www.ireps.gov.in>
587-PS/26
Follow us at [Facebook](https://www.facebook.com/NWR/Railways) [Instagram](https://www.instagram.com/NWR/Railways) [YouTube](https://www.youtube.com/NWR/Railways)

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Obituary
It is with deep sorrow that we announce the passing of **Mrs. Maheshwari Natarajan**, former Vice Principal of Vidya Mandir Mylapore, Founding Principal of Vidya Mandir Estancia & Director of AM Jain School, on **23.04.2026**.
A visionary leader and distinguished administrator, she will be remembered as much for her dynamic leadership, as for her gentle grace.
We pray for the peaceful passage of her noble soul.
The Vidya Mandir family

DEATH

SAD DEMISE

JOSEPH MICHAEL MENEZES
28th March 1934 - 22nd April 2026
"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."
2 Timothy 4:7
Viewing- Till 9 AM, 24th April 2026 @ B703, Radiance Mandarini, Thoraipakkam
Funeral- 24th April 2026, 9:30 AM Sagaya Madha Church, Thoraipakkam
Burial- 24th April 2026, 11:30 AM St. Mary's Corporation Christian Cemetery, Mandaveli Ph: 98848 44834

DEATH

HARDIK SHRADHANJALI

With profound grief, we inform the passing of Shri **BHAWARLAL JAIN (Age 73)** S/o. Late Shri Misraal Lunked who left us for his heavenly abode on 23rd April 2026 at 1:30 PM.
The funeral procession will take place on Friday 24th April 2026 at 12:05 PM from our residence to Choolai Mukthi Dharm. Residence: D 32, 5th Street, D Block, Anna Nagar, Chennai - 600 102.
We bow before the divine will, Mourning this irreplaceable loss with heavy hearts.
LUNKED FAMILY BHAWAR GROUP
Contact Nos: 9886776581 / 9840014780

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

6th Death Anniversary
In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Angul, Odisha recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 286 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Naharlagun, Arunachal Pradesh recorded a healthy AQI score of 23

MR. V. SRINIVASAN
DOD: 24th April 2020
Remembered by: Family Members

33rd ANNIVERSARY

You are forever in our heart. We love and miss you

NELLAI S. NAGALINGAM NADAR
Fondly remembered by: Family Members, Relatives, Friends & Employees
SNJ GROUP OF COMPANIES
D.O.B : 1940 D.O.D : 24.4.93

ANNIVERSARY

MATHUSRI P.V.PATTAMMAL
1915 - 24.04.2011
Reverential Homage to Dear Mother
Your Thoughts Keep us Driving
LEELA KALYANASUNDARAM +91 98947 41362
SWARNAM RAMAKRISHNAN 0422 2976352
BHAVANI RAMACHANDRAN +91 9962284895
Mrs. GEETHA / Mr. KRISHNAMURTHY 09894703153
subhalaharee@hotmail.com

Executive Engineer Office, P. W. Division No. 1, Thane Parking Plaza Building 8th Floor, Service Road, Off Eastern Express Highway, Near Jupiter Hospital, Thane - 400601.
www.mahapwd.com thane1.ee@mahapwd.gov.in 25369293
No./TD/Tender/4298 Date. 21/04/2026

E-Tender Corrigendum No. 2 (Time Table)
WORK NAME:- E-Tender No.55/01 Year 2025-26 Tender ID:- 2026_PWR_1292018_1 Construction Of 900 Bedded District Civil, And Super Specialty Hospital, Building Nursing Training Centre and Hostel Building at Civil Hospital Complex, Thane, Tal. Dist. Thane (Providing, Supplying and Fixing Furniture, Furniture Layout Audio and Video Systems for Auditorium Hall).
Estimated Cost :- 51,60,28,289.00
Ref:- E-Tender Notice No. 55 Year 2025-26 letter Dated No. This Office Letter No. Tender/3676 Date. 25/03/2026.

Sr. No.	Tender	Before Public Date	Now Public Date
1	Selling Date	01.04.2026 to 22.04.2026	01.04.2026 to 22.04.2026
2	Pre-bid Mitting		
3	Tender Opening Date	23.04.2026	27.04.2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer, P.W.Division No.1, Thane
DGIPR/2026-2027/394



Cycle of violence

Manipur sees little respite despite a change of guard under the BJP

Ethnic quagmires are among the most difficult situations for governments to untangle, given the violence and persistence of hostilities – even for those committed to restoring peace. The reason is the intransigent nature of ethnic divides, where hostile elements resist any efforts at normalisation. Any space for empathy is restricted as every incident is ethnicised. The situation is compounded when the government of the day fails to nip the descent into ethnicised hostilities in the bud, making it even more difficult for civil society and subsequent governments to restore peace and normalcy. This is the kind of situation that Manipur finds itself in. Even a relatively moderate Chief Minister such as Yumnam Khemchand Singh, who has sought – at least through nominal gestures – to rise above the ethnic fray, has found the going tough. Violence has flared up again following a bombing attack on April 7 that killed a five-year-old boy and an infant girl in Bishnupur district. Reports of the alleged involvement of a Kuki extremist organisation in bombing attacks – denied by Kuki groups – triggered a series of protests in the valley and renewed violence led to more deaths. With disinformation and rumour-mongering adding fuel to the fire, Manipur has returned to a cycle of violence and hardening stances among groups in its persistent ethnic quagmire.

The Bharatiya Janata Party initially believed that the resignation of former Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, efforts to curb violent ethnic organisations, and the passage of time would help restore normalcy. After a spell of President’s Rule, and in an apparent effort to promote a more moderate form of governance before elections are due, the BJP formed a new government under Mr. Khemchand Singh. However, the inadequate involvement of political leaders – including from the Union government – in a genuine peace-building exercise shows that the situation has not improved despite these nominal changes by the BJP. A more thoroughgoing carrot and stick approach, empowering civil society leaders willing to advance peace and punishing those promoting and engaging in violence, would have certainly helped. But political variables focused more on retaining power than achieving peace appear to have kept those seeking to advance hardline views in positions of influence on both sides of the divide. A more pro-active role by the Home Ministry and a genuine effort by the BJP to involve all political actors in easing tensions should help. This should be supplemented by a strategy that empowers security agencies to crack down on hardline elements engaging in wanton violence such as bombings. Short of these measures, Manipur will continue to convulse with recurring incidents of violence, reactions and reprisals.

High heat

India must address the underlying vulnerability to hot weather

India’s summers are known to be hot, but this year the high heat has arrived noticeably early. The India Meteorological Department has sounded heat alerts in central and south India, including in Vidarbha, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Telangana and Kerala. Parts of Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat have also scaled the 40°C mark, with Tamil Nadu and Karnataka not far behind. Local conditions in coastal areas, in particular, could be worse due to humidity and the urban heat island effect. Warmer nights also delay physiological recovery, increasing the local health-care burden. Such temperatures are usually encountered in May-June but have become apparent in April. While pre-monsoon heatwaves are common in India, they are becoming larger and more intense. This year, a lack of western disturbances and thunderstorms, along with lower convective activity, has also done away with natural cooling, with residual effects of the previous El Niño adding to the heat. Persistently high heat is linked to a significantly higher risk of death from cardiovascular causes. Some 247 billion work-hours were lost in 2024 to heat, according to *The Lancet* Countdown Global Report, with workers in construction and agriculture the most affected. Heat stress is an ongoing concern for farmers during the *rabi* harvest. Hot weather accelerates crop maturity, threatening food security and feeding inflationary pressure.

Experts have complained that most heat action plans (HAPs) – India’s primary institutional response to heat – focus on emergency response and lack funds for structural interventions such as urban re-greening and mandatory heat-safety legislation for workers in the informal sector. They have thus failed to address underlying vulnerabilities. On April 23, in the Tamil Nadu and West Bengal polls, and Gujarat and Maharashtra by-elections, lakhs of electors had to brave the heat. Concerns about voter turnout in the heat prompted the Election Commission of India to keep polling booths open longer during the 2024 general election; such reactive measures alone will not suffice this year. If warming continues along current trajectories, more than a few parts of India will begin approaching human survivability limits. HAPs desperately need sufficient, long-term funding while public systems must roll out mobile health units and doorstep delivery of essential services during peak heat to reduce the income penalties that deter access. Colombia has convened a coalition of roughly 50 countries to explore a faster transition away from fossil fuels in a parallel ‘climate conference’. India should join it, not least because of the greater access to climate adaptation finance it could afford.

The high-octane din of the ongoing Operation Epic Fury against Iran, which began on February 28, 2026, has largely subsumed an equally ferocious war being waged simultaneously in Lebanon. While this fracas between the Israeli Defense Forces (IDF) and Lebanon’s Hezbollah militia has some linkages to the Iranian imbroglio, it would be simplistic to regard it as a mere sideshow of the latter. The Lebanon conflict predates the formation of the Islamic Republic of Iran in 1979 and has its own background, drivers and ramifications.

A battleground

Indeed, for much of its 83 years as an independent nation, Lebanon, with a current population of five million, has been used as a springboard for foreign causes against Israel, with which it shares a 79-km land border. Following the creation of Israel in 1948, nearly 1,00,000 Palestinians took refuge in Lebanon. They eventually led to the establishment of the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO), based in Beirut, forming a state within the Lebanese state. The PLO, under its Chairman Yasser Arafat, conducted guerrilla activities against Israel, provoking Israeli wrath against Lebanon. A civil war broke out in Lebanon in 1975, pushing ethnic identities over nationalism. The PLO joined the conflict. In 1982 the IDF invaded Lebanon to expel it, causing the PLO to relocate to Tunis. However, most Palestinian residents remained in Lebanon and are now estimated at around 5,00,000, roughly one-tenth of the population. Syria, a neighbouring big brother under the al-Assad regime, also intervened in the civil war, maintaining a so-called “deterrent force” ostensibly to maintain order.

Lebanon’s relief at the PLO’s exit was short-lived. Revolutionary Iran soon waded in to seed the Hezbollah militia to collectivise and militarise the country’s sizable, but poorer, Shia population in the southern areas bordering Israel. Over the next few decades, Iran invested billions of dollars into bankrolling Hezbollah, transforming it into Lebanon’s most powerful militia, a Shia welfare organisation, and a key pillar of Iran’s “Axis of Resistance”. Through guerrilla tactics, Hezbollah fighters inflicted steady losses on the IDF, evicting it from the buffer zone in southern Lebanon in 2000. Subsequently, in 2006, Hezbollah fought off the IDF in a month-long conflict. This “success” prompted the militia’s conversion into a regular proto-army with a fortified Israeli border with sizeable missile and drone capabilities.

Following the Hamas attack on Israel on October 7, 2023, Hezbollah joined the battle against the IDF. In the autumn of 2024, Israel leveraged its deep intelligence penetration to devastating effect: decapitating Hezbollah hierarchy, including its long-time leader, Syed Hassan Nasrallah, and several regional commanders. In a dramatic manner, Israel simultaneously exploded a large number of



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador with an interest in West Asia and oil matters

Despite a tenuous ceasefire, Lebanon remains fragile; the scheduled second round of talks with Israel in Washington offers a sliver of hope

paggers and walkie-talkies to kill, maim, and demoralise hundreds of Hezbollah fighters. Hezbollah kept a steady barrage of missile and drone attacks, forcing many Israeli citizens to relocate from northern Israel. However, by the time of the ceasefire in late October 2024, Hezbollah had been reduced to a pale shadow of its former self. The fall of the al-Assad regime in Syria, which acted as a land bridge with Iran, was a serious setback. Although Hezbollah conspicuously stayed out of Iran’s 12-day war with Israel and the United States in June 2025, the degradation of Iranian defence capabilities impacted it. Within Lebanon, too, its political fortunes suffered, and the country was able to elect a Hezbollah-agnostic President and Prime Minister after a long hiatus. Under the new domestic political order, calls for disarming Hezbollah became more strident as the militia was seen more as the cause of the insecurity than as a self-proclaimed deterrent against Israel.

Conflict and engagement

Against this sombre backdrop, Israel and the U.S. suddenly launched a joint air campaign against Iran on February 28, 2026, assassinating Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in its first salvo. This shocked Hezbollah into attacking Israel with artillery, drones and missiles across the common border, breaking the 15-month ceasefire. The IDF responded in kind with intense air attacks on Hezbollah assets. Both sides internalised the lessons of the last round: Hezbollah used the interregnum to recoup its losses and make operational changes to avoid intelligence leakages. It revived guerrilla tactics, conserving its assets for a long war of attrition. It adopted a decentralised command structure and toned down its political rhetoric. The IDF initially avoided infantry engagements, deploying more armour and airpower.

After an Iranian ceasefire was announced on April 8, Tehran demanded that Lebanon be brought under its ambit. To the contrary, IDF intensified its attacks on Hezbollah, launching “100 air strikes in 10 minutes” and demolishing buildings without prior notice. The IDF depopulated much of the south to create, once again, a buffer zone south of the Litani river. After nine days of ferocious war, U.S. President Donald Trump declared a ceasefire on April 17. The announcement was preceded by a preliminary meeting on April 14 between the Israeli and Lebanese ambassadors in Washington, facilitated by U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio. This engagement was noteworthy for many reasons. It was the first contact since the abortive Madrid process in the mid-1990s between the two states formally still at war. The meeting took place despite Hezbollah’s stiff opposition and Iranian insistence on the matter being put under Iran-U.S. ceasefire negotiations. There was considerable opposition within Israel to the ceasefire from hardliners who wanted Hezbollah defanged. In the end, the interests of both the Israeli and Lebanese governments overlapped in

hiving off the Iranian connection to Hezbollah. The second round of bilateral talks is scheduled to take place in Washington on April 23, amid sporadic violations of the ceasefire. The second round of Iran-U.S. negotiations in Islamabad, Pakistan, remains stalled.

This Washington process also faces considerable challenges. First, the respective objectives of the stakeholders differ: Beirut wants a permanent ceasefire, an IDF withdrawal to the international border supervised by the United Nations peacekeepers and avoidance of any new civil war, as the Lebanese armed forces are too weak to take on Hezbollah. Jerusalem’s priority is just the opposite: to disarm Hezbollah even if it triggers a Lebanese civil war. On the other hand, Mr. Trump can hardly wait to conclude these negotiations to his list of peace deal trophies; he may eventually wish to include Lebanon among the Abraham Accord signatories. As Hezbollah is stubbornly unwilling to disarm, citing an existential threat from Israel, any reckless move in that direction could precipitate a civil war in a country still deeply fragmented along confessional/ethnic lines. This sensitive issue needs discreet handling, with Hezbollah being offered some assurances to persuade it to disarm. Besides, Lebanon, still recovering from the civil war (1975-1990), has faced two devastating conflicts with Israel in the past two years, which have left 5,282 people dead, displaced 1.2 million, and caused financial losses of \$8.5 billion. By early 2026, 35% of Lebanese were living below the national poverty line.

Hope amid prolonged crisis

Lebanon today is a cautionary tale of nearly half a century of accumulated crises, which its ossified nomenclatura swept under the carpet. An early resolution of the Lebanese imbroglio is as elusive as it is important for the country, the entire region and beyond. More Lebanese live outside Lebanon than in the country itself. Further, Lebanon is the only Arab country with a significant proportion of Christians. In the past, tensions between various confessions have sucked in their co-religionist foreign backers, exacerbating the problems. The converse is also true: Lebanese militias have often meddled abroad. Hezbollah, for instance, acted as a protector of Syria’s al-Assad regime and stirred the Shias in the Gulf states and supported al-Houthis in Yemen. At its best, a multi-ethnic Lebanon was a model state with a tolerant, productive and prosperous society that Indians related to. It was a civilisational bridge between Christian Europe and Muslim Arabs. It enriched the world beyond its microcosm – from philosopher Khalil Gibran to thinker Kamal Jumbblatt and from historian Philip Hitti to Arabic singer Fairuz. The past half-century has tormented Lebanon with fratricidal civil wars overlaid with foreign causes. The current ceasefire and talks offer a sliver of hope that this jinx has finally been broken and the country can cautiously move towards normalcy.

Scaling climate adaptation from policy to grassroots



Anjana Rajagopalan

Programme Manager with the Climate Resilience Practice programme at WRI India



Arivudai Nambi Appadurai

Director of the Climate Resilience Practice programme at the World Resources Institute India

Adaptation can be advanced through coordinated governance, finance and local efforts

efforts difficult. While India’s Economic Survey 2025-26 estimates adaptation and resilience spending at 5.6% of GDP in FY22, the Union Budget 2026-27 remains skewed toward mitigation.

Financing adaptation action

Developing countries face an annual financing gap of \$284-\$339 billion through 2035, as per the United Nations Environment Programme’s (UNEP) Adaptation Gap Report, 2025. As India looks to sharpen its adaptation focus, domestic resource mobilisation will be key – requiring a clear typology for adaptation finance (which is prioritisation of sectors and assessment of the resources required for each vulnerable sector). However, India’s Draft Framework of Climate Finance Taxonomy (2025) remains largely mitigation-focused and looks at emission avoidance, emission intensity reduction (with possible adaptation co-benefits) and activities supporting transition in hard-to-abate sectors.

It is vital to quantify adaptation benefits such as avoidable losses and socio-economic and environmental benefits including mitigation co-benefits. A WRI study estimates a ten-fold return on adaptation investment, making a case for leveraging private and international investment towards adaptation. Adaptation facilities at the state-level can help identify bankable adaptation projects that map benefits and widen the resource base.

Additionally, domestic public finance should be streamlined by tracking adaptation activities within State budgets, following which the Ministry of Finance can mandate climate budgeting through State Finance Departments. This can be integrated within annual budgetary planning processes through a budget circular. Such a mandate must incorporate timeframes for prioritisation of adaptation action with a monitoring framework. This should be complemented with cross-department consultative approaches and capacity building at

nodal departmental levels. NDCs are expected to be operationalised through a National Adaptation Plan, national missions and State Action Plans on Climate Change (SAPCCs). While most States drafted an initial SAPCC, only a few States submitted revisions in tune with NDC updates until 2030. Institutionalising planning requires regular climate vulnerability assessments at the State, district, and block levels, integrating socio-economic and livelihood factors. This calls for robust methodologies, updated data, capacity-building, and standardised monitoring, with periodic reviews and continuous data collection.

Adaptation strategies should ideally go beyond resilient infrastructure to encompass skill development, alternative livelihoods and guidelines for rehabilitation of affected populations. This can be done by leveraging existing State and district climate change cells or setting up new functional cells with a dedicated workforce. Clear reporting channels can further support cross-learning and timely interventions.

Facilitating locally led adaptation

Institutional mechanisms should extend to the level of urban local bodies and panchayati raj institutions to scale adaptation action. Locally Led Adaptation (LLA) was stressed at COP30. Co-developing resilience planning with communities – from planning and implementation to management, ownership, and leadership of needs-based interventions – is central to people-centric climate action. Applying place-based and context-specific approaches, such as extending the CRV initiative to different geographies, not only helps raise climate awareness but also enables communities to be a part of decision-making processes.

Preparedness for future climate impacts requires capacity-building and behavioural change across multiple levels. A whole-of-systems approach to adaptation is needed, where national commitments are met through grassroots action.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

‘Record’ voter turnout

The euphoria surrounding Tamil Nadu’s ‘historic voter turnout’ in the 2026 Assembly elections deserves a more sober examination. The real story lies not in voter enthusiasm

alone, but in a quiet statistical transformation engineered months before polling day. The Election Commission of India’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is the elephant in the room.

During this exercise, a staggering 97 lakh names were removed from the rolls — on grounds of death, duplication, migration, and other discrepancies — while only 30 lakh new voters were added. The net result:

Tamil Nadu’s electorate shrank from 6.29 crore in 2021 to 5.73 crore in 2026, a reduction of nearly 67 lakh voters, or 10.45% of the total base. The arithmetic consequence of this is straightforward. When the

denominator shrinks while the numerator remains roughly constant — or rises even marginally — the percentage climbs sharply. A simple back-of-the-envelope calculation confirms that

the polling percentage would rise by nearly 10 percentage points from 2021 levels, even if not a single additional voter showed up at the booth. **Ramachandran J.,** Virudhunagar, Tamil Nadu

Has a weakening of unionisation hurt workers?



Kingshuk Sarkar

Professor and Area Chair for general management and economics, Goa Institute of Management

PARLEY

Since March, the country has witnessed a number of agitations by workers, particularly by those in the manufacturing sector. In the background of these protests for minimum wages; expansion of the social security ambit; and against the contractualisation of jobs, the role of trade unions have come up for discussion. There have been concerns about the impact of deunionisation and how it has affected the workers. Kingshuk Sarkar and Fredy K. Thazhath discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **A. M. Jigeesh**.

What is the extent of the deunionisation among Indian workers?

Kingshuk Sarkar: Amidst the shifting global, political and economic landscape, the nature of the Indian labour movement, particularly the trade union movement, has undergone substantial changes over the last four decades. Before 1991, unions had relatively better bargaining power, mainly in the public sector. Post-liberalisation, mainstream trade unions gradually suffered from declining bargaining power as the labour market became predominantly informal, in the sense that these workers lack employment contracts or do not have access to institutional social security. Mainstream trade unions suffered from fragmentation and ideological divisions and this weakened trade union effectiveness. Trade unions mostly focused on the regular permanent workforce; and their penetration among the growing segment of contract workers was not high. Global competition and the weakening of regulatory regimes led to the deterioration in labour standards and wages. Secure, well-paid jobs have declined, replaced by flexible work arrangements and non-standard employment, including part-time, short-time, and self-employment. Also, younger workers have a negative perception about trade unions. Today, the unionisation rate among the workforce is only 6.3% – 1.8% in the private sector and 11.8% in the public sector. The recent enactment of the Labour Code is going to further aggravate the situation.

Fredy K. Thazhath: Challenges to the trade union movement have happened not just because of empirical adversities. It's because of the sharpening of the general crisis of capitalism and the resulting drive for fetishistic methods of outsourcing and fragmentation of industries. Unlike in many other capitalist countries, it was the working class that fanned the fire of the Indian freedom struggle. The working class



Living on the edge: Police officers patrol a street after workers demanded a wage hike, amid soaring prices, in Noida, Uttar Pradesh, on April 13. REUTERS

fought colonial rulers compelling them to make labour laws. When the republic was born, the fruits of those labour laws were reaped by the workers for the first two to three decades, called the dirigisme period. The public sector grew. But after the Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation (LPG) policies came in 1991, this was not the case. There has been a counter offensive from the side of capital, especially from finance capital and its adjutants. It is not that contract labour grew because of the timidity of the existing trade union movement, it is because of the impact of a general onslaught upon the working class, and because of the privatisation of public sector units, which led to those sections of the working class getting trimmed off, lessening its bargaining power. So it is a phenomena-based outcome, not just a behavioural outcome.

Forming a trade union is a fundamental right, but they are often seen as a “problem”. What has been the Indian experience?

KS: The growth of Indian trade unions and political developments are very closely related. Since 1991, we have seen a lot of outsourcing happening. A person may be working for an organised sector, but many do not have a direct relation with the employer. So sometimes it becomes difficult for trade unions to engage or mobilise workers as union members. Also, because of the political affiliations of mainstream trade unions, there have been misgivings among the workers as they see trade unions as an extension of the political ideology. In the public sector, employment decreased from 19.6 million in 1991 to 17.5 million in 2008. Economic reforms lead to the closure or downsizing of uncompetitive public sector units and traditional industries.

FKT: In regions such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu,



Mainstream trade unions suffered from fragmentation and ideological divisions and this weakened trade union effectiveness. Trade unions mostly focused on the regular permanent workforce; and their penetration among the growing segment of contract workers was not high

KINGSHUK SARKAR

when general strikes occur, contract unions are a part of it. The contracted workers are also unionised as separate entities. Even with this kind of an arrangement, the general drive was for the abolition of contractualisation. Now, because of LPG policies and the diminishing democratic atmosphere in the country – unlike in the days of the freedom struggle, when the working class struggle and the democratic struggle to overthrow imperialism went hand in hand – things have gotten worse. After Independence, the general democratic movement among the people helped to galvanise the worker-peasant alliance. It was not simply the legislative or statute part of trade union rights that helped the movement. But now because of the general onslaught, the working class movement has begun to fight defensively. The question of abolishing contractualisation and the question of making a living wage have gone behind the question of manifesting a minimum wage.

The present crisis is around a minimum wage for workers and increasing prices. Have the presence of trade unions helped the government and industries to amicably address these problems?

FKT: When trade union leaders are in house arrest, there is no furor in Parliament or Assemblies. There are no headlines in major newspapers. This is a kind of de-democratisation. A trade union is an agency within the capitalist system. It is not a revolutionary movement. So even though it is within the system, it is curtailed and not at all talked about. And this is because of the political and economic perspective of LPG policies.

KS: The apparent reason behind this unrest in the national capital region is that the minimum wage was not enough for subsistence. State governments decide the minimum wage, determined by a minimum wage advisory board. It is a tripartite, equally represented committee, with representatives from the trade union, the employers and the government. So trade unions have a role to play in the revision of minimum

wages. They should be more vocal within this tripartite labour administrative structure so that the voices of workers are raised and States are compelled to revise minimum wages.

Another issue is that labour market dynamics are creating more problems for trade unions because we have so much of surplus labour coming out of agriculture. Agriculture provides only 14% of the national income, but the employment share of agriculture is more than 45%. This labour needs to be meaningfully employed in the industrial and tertiary sector, which is not happening.

The implementation of the four Labour Codes is being projected as a solution. What do you think is the way forward for addressing the problems of workers?

KS: The Labour Codes do not favour the workers, it is in some cases favouring the employers. However, it is not a huge change from the laws that we already had. Under the labour laws, minimum wages become more progressive because minimum wage has been added to all employments.

However, in the last 40 years, whatever that has been already mentioned in the labour laws have not been implemented. Rather than formalising the informal, our labour force has become more informal over the years in spite of a protective labour law framework being there. So I think the situations are different but we should go back to the basics. Whatever that is there for the workers should be implemented.

FKT: It is a fight for survival. In the last three decades, apart from defensive general strikes, nobody can cite sector-wise indefinite strikes or floor level strikes with aggressive demands. Now, it is evident from the Labour Codes that the capitalists are not happy with even contractualisation. The state, and the oligarchy corporates are going for ‘fixed term employment’. This is a phenomena-based situation, because of which phenomena-based outbreaks happens.

Under the Labour Codes, trade unions cannot be formed without 10% of the workforce; unlike in the earlier case of eight workers coming together and forming a trade union. There is no statutory supervision by the Labour Department at all. This is a catastrophic phenomena-based outcome, and not a behavioural issue of existing trade unions.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

A season to try and understand the people’s pulse

While journalists cannot ignore digital platforms, only field reporting offers a clear understanding of the public sentiment

D. Suresh Kumar

As India headed for a snap poll after the fall of the I.K. Gujral government, Congress leader Sonia Gandhi was to make her debut election speech on January 11, 1998, in Sriperumbudur, where former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated seven years earlier. Among the crowd when one raised the slogan “Sonia Gandhi!..”, the rest responded: “Zindabad.” I asked them what it meant. They had no idea. Noticing my smile, one asked, “Saar, you tell us. Did we say something wrong?” I shrugged. The next instance, he switched to “Vandemataram!” and looked at me for approval. I smiled again and walked to the press gallery to hear Sonia Gandhi say: “I stand today on the soil drenched by the blood of my husband who died a martyr for the unity of the country.”

Such encounters were common during the elections. Two years earlier, amid resentment against Chief Minister J. Jayalalitha (as she spelt her name then), an elderly woman loudly criticised the regime. But when asked whom she would vote for, she replied firmly: “*Rettai Illai*” (All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)’s ‘Two Leaves’). Wasn’t that Jayalalitha’s symbol? “*Adhu MGR chinnam* (That’s MGR’s symbol),” she said, revealing her emotional bond with party founder M. G. Ramachandran.

Villagers were eager to talk – offering flavoured goli soda or tea, asking which paper we worked for, and whether their photos would be published. Some, though, shied away from the camera. Reading the public mood was rarely easy unless there was a clear “wave.” Some voters would ask, “Who do you want us to vote for?” Others wore their loyalty literally, with party tattoos. A Scheduled Caste voter in Gummidipoondi said, “We first voted for MGR. We should not change midway. Till our death it will be ‘*Rettai Illai*’.”

Wave elections – such as the 2004 Lok Sabha polls or the 1996 and 2011 Assembly elections – made trends easier to spot. In

2004, it was clear in the Vanniyar regions of Cuddalore, Villupuram and Dharmapuri that superstar Rajinikanth’s appeal against the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) had limited effect; even his ardent fans were politically divided. Ground realities often diverged from city-centric assumptions. In 2011, despite the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) delivering free TVs, subsidised rice, and gold for mangalsutra, the decisive issue in many districts was the prolonged power cuts. Livelihood disruptions mattered more than policy narratives, pushing the DMK to the third place in the Assembly.

Even welfare schemes were viewed differently. In Mettupalayam, an elderly man criticised the Kalaigarn Health Insurance Scheme: “Why pay private hospitals? Improve government hospitals instead.” Farmers, in the early years of the rural employment scheme, complained of labour shortages making agriculture unviable. Such interactions enriched reporting. In 1998, at a Communist Party of India (Marxist) rally in Chennai, an elderly woman fumed over a 25-50 paise bus fare hike. After the Lok Sabha defeat, Chief Minister Karunanidhi rolled it back.

Now, often, the first question we encounter is: “YouTuber ah?”. Voters and journalists are influenced by the noise of social media – party IT narratives, know-all commentators offering multiple takes on the same topic across platforms, confident “Forrest Gump”-like voices waxing eloquent on every event/personality, and even food vloggers pushing paid political content. Politicians, too, have adapted – funding YouTube channels, and staging interviews with celebrities.

In this clutter, identifying real issues is harder than ever. While journalists cannot ignore the digital discourse, only field reporting offers a clearer sense of the public pulse. When journalism falls short, it is often because it echoes social media narratives or theorisation instead of listening to people on the ground.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

The beat of the polls



Drummer boys: Artists who were engaged by political parties for a rally return home as the campaigning period for the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections drew to a close in Ramanathapuram on April 21. The State went to polls on Thursday, with voter turnout exceeding 80%. BALACHANDAR L.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 24, 1976

First consignment of fireworks shipped to U.S.

Madras, April 23: The first consignment of 875 packets of Sivakasi-made fireworks valued at Rs. 1.6 lakhs was shipped to the United States to-day.

This is the first time that fireworks are being sent to the U.S. meant for its bicentennial celebrations. To-day’s consignment is part of an order of Rs. 15 lakhs secured by a fireworks firm of Sivakasi. Mr. S.P. Ambrose, Chairman, Madras Port



Trust, who inaugurated the first shipment aboard an American liner S.S. Alaskan Mail congratulated the Sivakasi firm on having broken the monopoly of China in the U.S. market. A great responsibility lay on the fireworks manufacturers not only in ensuring the quality and retaining the U.S. market but also in increasing the export of fireworks to other countries. He called upon manufacturers, shippers and chambers of commerce to join together in increasing the exports.

Mr. K.S.G Haja Shareeff, President, Southern India Chamber of Commerce and Industry, presiding said this prestigious shipment would pave the way to develop this trade and make it an important item of export from the country.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 24, 1926

Protecting public against money-lenders

London, April 23: A Government undertaking to do its utmost to secure the passage of the Bill to protect the public against the money-lenders were given by Sir Wm. Joynsou-Hicks in the House of Commons and the Bill passed its second reading without division, after some objection had been raised with regard to some of its provisions. The mover of the Bill, Major R. Glyn said that the Bill laid down that the moneylenders shall take out an annual licence at a cost of £15. No money-lenders circulars or advertisement shall be sent to anybody except at the latter’s written request.

From Page One

93% polling as 152 seats in Bengal go to polls

A clash broke out in Murshidabad district under Naoda Assembly seat as Trinamool Congress supporters raised slogans against Aam Janata Unnayan Party founder Humayun Kabir, who is contesting the polls from the seat. Personnel of the Central armed police forces prevented both Mr. Kabir and his supporters and Trinamool workers from coming towards each other but the situation remained tense. The region has been volatile since Wednesday evening when a crude bomb was hurled at the Trinamool candidate.

In two separate incidents of violence, BJP candidates were targeted on polling day. The BJP candidate from Kumarganj Assembly seat in Dakshin Dinajpur, Subhendu Sarkar, was chased and beaten up by a group of people when he was visiting a polling booth.

In the video captured by media persons, locals are seen chasing and beating the BJP candidate, even as his security guard is trying to resist the attack. Five persons have been arrested in connection with the violence. In another incident, the vehicle of BJP candidate from Asansol Dakshin, Agnimitra Paul was attacked.

Polling was held across 16 districts – eight each in southern and northern Bengal.

The second phase of polling will be held on April 29 for the remaining 142 seats, which are located in and around Kolkata. There are a total of 294 seats in the Assembly and the results will be out on May 4.

SC questions ED’s claim of rule of law breach

The top law officer submitted that the argument of rule of law was raised to establish the *locus standi* of the ED, acting in a “representative capacity”, to approach the top court in an Article 32 writ petition to enforce the fundamental rights of its officials whose personal liberty and dignity as citizens were threatened by “engineered or orchestrated” police FIRs.

The ED and its Deputy Director Robin Bansal have filed a plea seeking a CBI probe into the incident.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, for the State government, argued that the Centre, and not the ED, ought to have approached the Supreme Court against the State by filing an original suit under Article 131 of the Constitution.

Mr. Mehta said a Centre versus State dispute did not arise here, adding that an Article 131 suit was filed only if the dispute was of a federal nature. “This is a law and order issue. The president of the ruling party, who is also the highest executive of the State, along with officials who happen to draw their salaries from the Centre are on one side here...Besides, State governments, including the States of West Bengal and Tamil Nadu [in the Governor case], have repeatedly approached the Supreme Court under Article 32, and been entertained by this court,” Mr. Mehta said. He said the filing of writ petitions by States should be “discouraged”. “Then should we dismiss this petition?” Justice Mishra asked.

Mr. Mehta replied in the negative, saying ED officials too had approached the Supreme Court in their personal capacity in this case.

Trump orders strike against Iran vessels

Iran has vowed it would keep the strait closed to all but a trickle of approved vessels for as long as the U.S. Navy blockades its ports, brushing off demands from Mr. Trump to both reopen Hormuz and surrender its enriched uranium.

“The first revenue received from the Strait of Hormuz tolls was deposited into the Central Bank account,” said deputy Speaker of Iran’s parliament, Hamidreza Hajibabaei, according to Tasnim news agency.

Air defence systems were activated in parts of Tehran on Thursday evening amid reports of hostile aerial activity, Iranian state media said in the first such reports since a ceasefire began. The Mehr news agency reported that the systems were activated in several parts of the capital to counter “hostile targets”, without elaborating further.

Meanwhile, it was still unclear when, or if, the two sides would meet again in the Pakistani capital, Islamabad, where mediators are trying to bring the countries together to reach a diplomatic deal.

Pooram scaled down after Thrissur tragedy

Core ceremonies such as *Ilanjithara Melam* and *Madathil Varavu* will proceed as scheduled, and 15 elephants each will be lined up for the processions. Both the main fireworks display at night and the daytime fireworks have been completely dropped. Instead, a symbolic bursting of *Kathina* will be carried out.

The government had initially proposed cancelling both *Kudamattam* and fireworks. However, Devaswom authorities insisted that *Kudamattam*, a central ritual, could not be omitted. The meeting ultimately accepted this position while agreeing to scale it down.

Cong. slams Modi govt. on Israel-Gaza conflict stance

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday accused the Narendra Modi government of maintaining “silence” on the ongoing conflict in Gaza, alleging that no previous dispensation had displayed such “solidarity” with a “murderous regime” in Israel.

In a post on X, Congress communication chief Jairam Ramesh said the Prime Minister’s response to Israel’s military actions in Gaza and Lebanon reflected “moral cowardice”. He flagged the continued displacement of Palestinians in the West Bank.

“There has been no government that has shown so much solidarity with the murderous Israeli regime as the Modi Govt that has betrayed all human values, apart from traditional Indian principles and positions,” Mr. Ramesh said in his post on X. The Congress has, in recent weeks, stepped up its criticism of the government’s West Asia policy. The party also criticised Mr. Modi’s visit to Israel earlier this year, stating that it came at a time when civilian casualties in Gaza were mounting.

‘Indian ties with Africa signal stability in a turbulent world’

Jaishankar highlights that India-Africa partnership is rooted in shared anti-colonial history and strengthened through capacity building, development cooperation, and strategic engagement

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

India’s relationship with Africa delivers a message of “stability in a turbulent world”, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said on Thursday. Speaking at the launch of the theme, website and logo of the upcoming fourth India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS-IV), Mr. Jaishankar said India’s ties with Africa were rooted in the common struggle for freedom from colonial rule. He highlighted development partnership and capacity building as key areas of collaboration between the two sides.

“As the world navigates through complex geopolitical and geoeconomic challenges, our partnership assumes particular significance. It will be a message of stability in a turbulent world, of reliability in an uncertain one and of solidarity in difficult times,” Mr. Jaishankar said, presenting the India-Africa partnership as a process that will strengthen institutions and empower people.



External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar with African Ambassadors and delegates at the India-Africa Forum Summit in New Delhi. ANI

The Minister made the remarks while launching the theme, logo and website of IAFS-IV, to be held from May 28 to 31. The event was attended by New Delhi-based heads of missions and Ambassadors of African countries. The third edition of the India-Africa Forum Summit was held in October 2015. The theme of the upcoming summit is “Enduring partnership – shared vision”.

Mr. Jaishankar’s remarks obliquely referred to the situation in the Gulf region, which has come into focus over the past two

months due to the U.S.-Israel war on Iran that has triggered a global energy crisis. In view of disruptions in the supply of essential items such as petroleum, natural gas, and fertilizers, India is looking for stable alternative suppliers, with several African countries seen as potential partners. With disruptions in fertilizer supplies from Gulf countries such as Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and Bahrain, India is expected to focus on Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, and Morocco to meet demand ahead of the next monsoon season.

Cong. questions EC notice to Kharge, alleges ulterior motives, casual approach

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday wrote to the Election Commission (EC) questioning the issuance of a show-cause notice to party president Mallikarjun Kharge, alleging “ulterior motives” and a “casual, routine manner” in the notice issued to Mr. Kharge.

In a letter addressed to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the two Election Commissioners, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh flagged that two notices bearing the same reference number and date – April 22 – had been issued but signed by different officials, with no clarity on whether one had been withdrawn.

Mr. Ramesh also pointed to discrepancies in the contents of the notices, noting that while one cited a complaint by Trinamool Congress leader Derek O’Brien, the other version uploaded on the EC website omitted any mention of the complainant.

This, he said suggested



It almost seems the CEC is executing the notice as a formality rather than as an act in discharge of natural justice

JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress general secretary (communications)

that notices were being issued mechanically based on complaints aligned with the ruling party’s position.

The Congress further objected to the 24-hour deadline given to Mr. Kharge to respond, describing it as insufficient given his ongoing poll campaign engagements. The party has sought a week’s time to submit a reply.

“It almost seems the CEC is executing the notice as a formality rather than as an act in discharge of natural justice. We seek time to file a detailed response within one week and also for a senior delegation of Congress leaders to present the same,” Mr. Ramesh’s letter said.

Code violations

The party also accused the EC of overlooking alleged

violations of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) by senior BJP leaders.

Mr. Ramesh cited Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s recent address to the nation following the failure to pass the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, claiming that his remarks included direct political attacks on the Congress, including accusing of foeticide during an election period.

“It almost seems that an attempt is being made to deliberately overlook the clear and unequivocal explanation about the context in which the words were uttered, so as to find some way to take action against the Congress president. Unfortunately, it smacks of ulterior motives,” Mr. Ramesh’s five page letter to Chief Election Commissioner said.

U.P. CM warns of possible unrest on Labour Day

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has cautioned against possible industrial unrest in the State around May 1 (Labour Day) and has instructed district administrations to be on high alert.

The directive comes days after a massive protest by industrial workers in Gautam Buddha Nagar district.

“Officials were directed to remain extremely alert and ensure effective preventive action before any situation arises. Referring to recent attempts to create industrial unrest in certain areas, he (Mr. Adityanath) stated that although the situation is currently normal, there is a possibility of renewed attempts between April 30 and May 2. Industrial unrest will not be tolerated under any circumstances, and such malicious attempts must be firmly thwarted,” a statement said. He made the remarks while chairing a high-level review meeting via video-conferencing on Wednesday.

MEA terms Trump’s ‘hellhole’ post on India ‘inappropriate’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre on Thursday called posts by U.S. President Donald Trump that quoted derogatory remarks about India and Indian immigrants as “uninformed, inappropriate and in poor taste”.

The posts, which included a video by American right-wing anchor Michael Savage and the four-page text of his comments, called countries such as India and China “hellholes” while criticising U.S. immigration laws.

The response from the Ministry of External Affairs came after Opposition members and former diplomats criticised the government for not offering a stronger response to the U.S. The Congress, in particular, mounted a sharp attack accusing the Prime Minister of “being afraid of” the U.S. in the face of repeated insults.

“The remarks are obviously uninformed, inappropriate and in poor taste. They certainly do not reflect the reality of the India-U.S relationship, which has long been based on mutual respect and shared interests,” the MEA spokesperson said late on Thursday night. Earlier in the day, at a briefing, the government had decided to take a safer approach however, with the MEA spokesperson saying only that they had “seen some reports”.

Addressing viewers of the “Savage Report” on Newsmax channel, Mr.

India, Egypt advance their defence cooperation

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India and Egypt advanced their defence cooperation at the 11th Joint Defence Committee meeting held in Cairo from April 20 to 22, outlining a road map to deepen bilateral engagement.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the Indian delegation, led by Joint Secretary (International Cooperation) Amitabh Prasad, engaged with senior Egyptian defence officials to review progress since the previous meeting and identify new avenues of collaboration. Both sides agreed on a bilateral defence cooperation plan for 2026-27, focusing on expanding military engagements, intensifying joint training exchanges, boosting maritime security cooperation, and increasing the scope of military exercises.

The two nations agreed to work towards a defence industry cooperation plan, exploring opportunities for co-development and co-production, it added. The inaugural Navy-to-Navy staff talks were held, underlining the importance of maritime cooperation.



Donald Trump

Savage had said that the U.S. had gone “from the melting pot to the chamber pot”, as a result of the relaxed immigration laws, comments that were then reposted by Mr. Trump on his “Truth Social” page. “A baby here becomes an instant citizen, and then they bring the entire family in from China or India or some other hellhole on the planet,” he said, comparing Indians and Chinese immigrants unfavourably to “European Americans of today and their ancestors” including Irish, Italian, Polish, Lithuanians, Romanians and Russians, and questioning their loyalty to America.

Embassy response

Asked about whether the view amplified by Mr. Trump was endorsed by the U.S. Embassy or U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor, the Embassy spokesperson quoted Mr. Trump as saying that “India is a great country with a very good friend of mine (Narendra Modi) at the top”. The U.S. embassy did not explain or backpedal the comments, which is understood to have upset the government.



Master Dastak Shende, Christian Medical College, Hospital No.AJ82370, 5 years has been Diagnosed to have Beta Thalassemia Major. This is a type of Life threatening Blood Disorder. The best option for him would be to undergo Allogeneic Peripheral Blood Stem Cell Transplant (PBSCIT). The Estimated cost of PBSCIT at this Hospital is Approximately Rs.16,00,000/-
Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives A/c** Dakshit Shende, **Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487, S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE:SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.
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APPEAL



Palestinian Authority says Israeli fire kills 15-year-old in West Bank



Russia reports toxic rain as oil depot hit in Ukraine strike

City officials on Wednesday warned residents to close windows, limit outdoor activities and wear face masks if they need to go outside.

North Korea, Russia aim to open new bridge linking two countries



U.K., France to sign border deal to curb small-boat migrant crossings



Israel awaiting U.S. green light to 'return Iran to Stone Age': Minister



Lebanon, Israel to resume rare direct talks in Washington to extend truce

10 people killed in attack at mining facility in Pakistan's Balochistan

The company acknowledged the attack late on Wednesday, saying security forces responded "promptly and have secured the area".

China selects two Pakistani candidates as its first foreign astronauts: reports

U.T. OF LAKSHADWEEP
LAKSHADWEEP DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVT. OF INDIA UNDERTAKING)
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23.04.2026

Sd/- General Manager

INBRIEF



Dhruv Sheoran opens up a three-shot lead

Dhruv Sheoran fired a six-under 66 to open up a three-shot lead at 15-under 201 after the third round of the DP World Players Championship at Nuh, Haryana. The 31-year-old delivered a second consecutive 66. Sunit Chowrasia (70, 66, 68), who returned from a long injury lay-off earlier this year, climbed to second at 12-under 204 after a steady four-under 68 that had five birdies and a lone bogey. Akshay Sharma (70, 65, 70) and Jamal Hossain (67, 70, 68) are tied third at 11-under 205.



Shanto, Mustafizur star in Bangladesh's series triumph

Najmul Hossain Shanto's century and Mustafizur Rahman's five-wicket haul helped Bangladesh thrash New Zealand by 55 runs in the third ODI and clinch the series 2-1 at Chattogram on Thursday. The 2-1 triumph marked Bangladesh's third straight series victory in the 50-over format following wins over the West Indies and Pakistan.

The scores: Bangladesh 265/8 in 50 overs (Najmul Hossain Shanto 105, Liton Das 76) bt New Zealand 210 in 44.5 overs (Nick Kelly 59, Dean Foxcroft 75, Mustafizur Rahman 5/43). **Toss:** NZ; **PoM:** Shanto; **PoS:** Nahid Rana.

Liam Rosenior sacked as Chelsea manager

Liam Rosenior has been sacked as Chelsea manager following a run of five successive Premier League defeats, the club announced on Wednesday.

Blasters edge Odisha in ISL with stoppage time winner

A stoppage time header from substitute Matias Hernandez gave Kerala Blasters a 2-1 win over visiting Odisha FC in the ISL match at the Jawaharlal Nehru stadium in Kochi on Thursday. Blasters took the lead through Victor Bertomeu in the 12th minute but Odisha rallied to get the equaliser from the boot of Rahim Ali in the 27th minute.

The result: Kerala Blasters 2 (Victor Bertomeu 12, Matias Hernandez 90+4) bt Odisha FC 1 (Rahim Ali 27).

Yamal out for rest of season but may be fit for World Cup

Lamine Yamal will miss the rest of Barcelona's season but should be healed from a leg injury in time to play for Spain at the World Cup, the club said on Thursday. The 18-year-old will miss the remaining six LaLiga games for the leader as he follows "conservative treatment" to heal a muscle injury in his left leg that he picked up on Wednesday while converting a penalty.



Cricket stadium construction begins at Pomona for LA28

A ground-breaking ceremony was held on the Fairplex Grounds at Pomona, about 50km from Los Angeles, California, for the construction of a cricket stadium marking the game's return to the Olympics in LA28 after 128 years.

LIVE TELECAST

Golf: China Open, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 10 a.m.

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & FanCode, 5 & 7.30 p.m.

IFL: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 6.30 p.m.

IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.

Bundesliga: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 12 a.m. (Saturday)

LaLiga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Saturday)

Wu, Ham gain two-stroke lead on the opening day

Bhullar best among Indians in the first round at the Sentosa Golf Club; Shiv delivers a stunning hole-in-one on par-three hole two, but eventually stands at T-117; Karandeep and Jeev disappoint

SINGAPORE OPEN

S. Shrivathsan
SINGAPORE

Thailand's Ekpharit Wu and Jeongwoo Ham of South Korea were the early pacesetters, while Gaganjeet Bhullar was the best-performing Indian in the Singapore Open first round at the Sentosa Golf Club here on Thursday.

Wu and Ham earned a two-stroke lead with impressive performances of seven-under-64. Wu, starting from tee 10, produced five birdies on his front nine to be quick off the blocks, with Ham matching him despite a bogey on hole 10. "Having my wife (his caddie) by my side makes me more confident. It has been a rewarding partnership," said Wu.

Bhullar, part of the chasing pack, was tied sixth after carding four-under-67 in a bogey-free effort. The 37-year-old, who began from tee 10, rode on three birdies on his back nine – holes one, four and seven – to be among a seven-member club at T-6.

"Given that I had four birdies and 14 pars, it was a consistent round of golf. I was in the game through the 18 holes. I would love to continue the form and multiply my belief in the next three rounds," said Bhullar, expressing satisfaction.

Shiv Kapur hit the headlines when he delivered a stunning hole-in-one on



Even battle: Wu was quick off the blocks, but Ham matched him despite a bogey. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the par-three hole two, but he was well off the pace during the rest of his four-over tale and eventually stood at T-117.

"I have been playing on the Asian Tour for about 22 years, and this was my first ace. The hole-in-one put a smile on my face.

"It was a silver lining on what was an otherwise

tough day," said Shiv.

Fellow Indians Shaurya Bhattacharya, Ajeetesh Sandhu and Rashid Khan were tied-29th with shows of one-under, while Karandeep Kochhar (T-54) and Jeev Milkha Singh (T-133) – who struggled to adapt to the energy-sapping conditions – had a disappointing day.

Top scores: 64: Ekpharit Wu (Tha) and Jeongwoo Ham (Kor); **66:** Charles Porter (USA), Aidric Chan (Phi) and Kieran Vincent (Zim); **67:** John Catlin (USA), Will Florimo (Aus), Kevin Yuan (Aus), Gaganjeet Bhullar (Ind), Tomohiro Ishizaka (Jpn), Luis Masaveu (Esp) and Ryosuke Kinoshita (Jpn).

(The writer is in Singapore at the invitation of The International Series).

WFI brings in four foreign coaches to train grapplers for marquee events

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

The Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) and the Sports Authority of India (SAI) have finalised four coaches, including high performance director Ian Butler from the USA, to train the country's elite wrestlers in the run-up to this year's Asian Games and 2028 Olympics.

The other three coaches are Shako Bentinaidis, Gogi Koguashvili and Kosei Akaishi. They are expected to sign their contracts next week. Hailing from Georgia, Bentinaidis, a three-time Olympian and a former European champion, is well known as Olympic medallist Bajrang Punia's personal coach.

Under Bentinaidis' guidance, Bajrang bagged two Worlds medals, Tokyo Olympics bronze and



Credentials: Bentinaidis is well known as the World and Olympic medallist Bajrang's personal coach. INSTAGRAM/EMZARIOS BENTINIDIS

Asian Games gold. Bentinaidis, who has also coached international athletes to Worlds and European medals, will work with India's freestyle wrestlers.

Koguashvili, a five-time World championships medallist and a 1992 Olympics bronze medallist, has worked as the head coach of Russia's national team and led them to 62 Worlds

top positions in Japan's high performance department during the Tokyo and Paris Olympics.

In his coaching career spanning more than 25 years, Akaishi has guided several athletes, such as Kyoko Hamaguchi and Yukako Kawai, to Olympic medals. He will coach the women.

Butler is a professional fighter and world-level grappler. Competing across global combat sports platforms, he has secured multiple medals. The founder and owner of Silverback Wrestling Club, Butler has worked with the USA and Canada teams.

He will coordinate between Indian and foreign coaches, monitor training plans and athletes' progress, ensure good communication across camps and ensure accountability for better performance.

Priyanuj, Ritvik emerge u-19, u-17 Natl. TT champions

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN

Assam's Priyanuj Bhattacharya staged a remarkable comeback to defeat Tamil Nadu's P.B. Abhinand 4-2 in the under-19 boys' singles final at the junior and youth National table tennis championships here on Thursday.

The results (final): Boys: U-19: Priyanuj Bhattacharya (Ass) bt P. B. Abhinand (TN) 4-2 (8-11, 9-11, 11-8, 11-4, 11-8, 11-8). **Doubles:** Abhinand and M.R. Balamurugan (TN) bt Senthil Kumar Mehan and Umesh Kumar (TN) 3-1 (11-6, 8-11, 11-4, 11-5).

U-17: Ritvik Gupta (J&K) bt Sathnak Arya (Od) 4-3 (11-8, 5-11, 9-11, 11-8, 6-11, 11-7). **Doubles:** Sahil Rawat & Dhairya Rawat (PSPBA) bt Trishal Raj Kumar & Rushikesh Jagtap (PSPBA) 3-2 (11-8, 8-11, 5-11, 11-8, 11-7).

City goes ahead of Arsenal; Barca wins

EURO LEAGUES

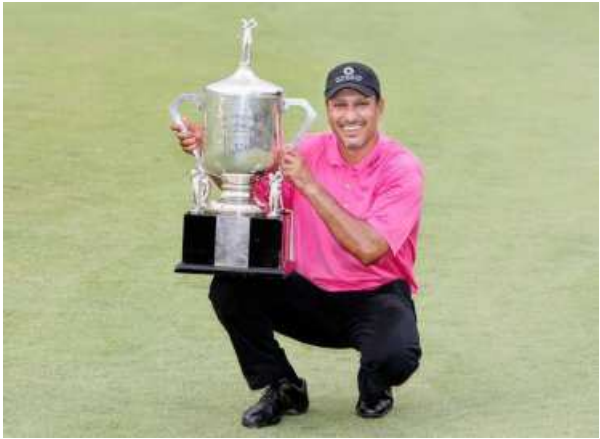
Agence France-Presse
BURNLEY

Manchester City edged ahead of Arsenal at the top of the Premier League as a 1-0 victory condemned Burnley to relegation on Wednesday. Erling Haaland scored the only goal as Pep Guardiola's men ended the day top for the first time since August

City goes ahead of the Gunners only on goals scored, with five games

left. Barcelona moved a step closer to winning La Liga with a tight 1-0 victory over Celta Vigo on Wednesday. Lamine Yamal won and converted a penalty to clinch a narrow triumph.

The results: **Premier League:** Bournemouth 2 (Kroupi 60, Rayan 85) drew with Leeds 2 (Hill 68-og, Longstaff 90+7). Burnley 0 lost to Manchester City 1 (Haaland 5). **LaLiga:** Elche 3 (Affengruber 18, Silva 33-pen, 75) bt Atletico Madrid 2 (Gonzalez 10, 36). Real Sociedad 0 lost to Getafe 1 (Gorrotxategi 29-og); Barcelona 1 (Yamal 40-pen) bt Celta Vigo 0.



Fortuitous: Jeev attributed his 2008 Singapore Open success to a timely intervention and 'god's work.' FILE PHOTO

How a Thai referee's intervention helped Jeev clinch the 2008 Singapore crown

S. Shrivathsan
SINGAPORE

Jeev Milkha Singh had a hard time in the first round of the Singapore Open on Thursday.

But moments after he was done for the day, the elder statesman of Indian golf left his struggles behind; in fact, during an interaction with the media, the 54-year-old was in the mood to take a trip down memory lane and reminisce his 2008 triumph here.

Jeev revealed how the intervention of a Thai referee, who had watched the action unfold from miles away, and 'god's work' played a part in the Indian going all the way.

Amazing story

"The story is amazing; I would have been disqualified in the first round. I was on my fourth hole (13th on the course).

"I put my ball down and the ball moved. The rule is that if the ball moves, you cannot pick it up. But I did

AROUND THE CITY

Lalith's century powers Chennai Port

R.S. Lalith's 105 powered Chennai Port to a 53-run victory over KMC in a TNCA IV-C match recently. In another contest, left-arm spinner S. Vishnu Dev's five for 37 helped BRC skittle out Vigneswara for just 66 and win by 91 runs.

The scores: IV-C: Chennai Port 289/8 in 50 overs (S. Salman Khan 31, R.S. Lalith 105, S. Surender 68, S. Thilak 45 n.o.), bt KMC 236/8 in 50 overs (M. Sanjeevan 108, D. Yuvraj Yadav 30, A.K. Balachander 3/20). Triplicane CC 152 in 44.2 overs (Moksh Bhaiya 30 n.o., A. Rithan Kumar 4/23) lost to Unicorn 153/6 in 31 overs (M. Sakthivel 62, Moksh Bhaiya 4/53).



Star performers: Lalith (Chennai Port, 105), Vishnu (BRC, 5/37), Sanjeevan (KMC, 108), Vanssh (Vigneswara, 5/28).

SBI 120 in 42.4 overs (R.G. Barat Raj 32, M. Arun Kumar 3/22, A. Prabudeva 3/24) lost to Bharat Petroleum 124/4 in 17.5 overs (R. Piruthivi 35, V.K. Nivedhan 32, A. Prabudeva 35 n.o.).

PUC 181 in 44 overs (K. Lakshmanan 55, T. Shakthi Eshwar 58, M. Prathamesh 3/35, M.P. Abhiman Sundar 3/44) lost to Book Sellers XI 182/3 in 33.1 overs (M. Abiseek 46, R. Jadan Jonah David 48, R. Jeremiah Allan Marcus 35 n.o.).

Kumbhat 171 in 49.5 overs (S. Vinay 68, Mohan Kumar Devaraj 30, R. Aravind Krishna 3/42, G. Selvakumar 3/30, G. Rohith 3/37) lost to Chatnath 176/2 in 30.5 overs (M. Sivanesh 87 n.o., N. Balasubramani 30, Kanishka. C. Aravind 34 n.o.).

BRC 157 in 36.4 overs (K. Rithish 42, J. Rejan Abinav 39, Vanssh Kumar Jain 5/28) bt Vigneswara 66 in 22.4 overs (V. Aravind 33, S. Vishnu Dev 5/37, S. Manikandan 3/13).

KDCA u-19 and u-16 trials this weekend

The Kanchipuram District Cricket Association (KDCA) will conduct trials for the under-19 and -16 teams at 7 a.m. on April 25 and April 26 respectively at Sankara Arts and Science College, Enathur.

Contact Dr. K.R. Venkatesan at 96299 00292 for further details.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA-TDCA league, I Div. playoffs, Qualifier 1, Standard Ambattur vs. Seshadri Memorial, 9.30 a.m., Magna-A. Friends inter-academy u-12 tournament, 8 a.m., N.M. Greens.



Tryst with success – the Tilak-Abhishek redemption

CM
YK

HEALTH

Pathogens without payback: when sharing isn't caring

Poorer nations that share critical pathogen data often benefit little from the health outcomes developed using that data; the long overdue PABS framework is critical to fixing this system; with another round of negotiations beginning on April 27, a lot is riding on how quickly and effectively both parties find common ground

Harsh Kabra

When contagions don't discriminate, why should cures? That question encapsulates a bitter irony of global public health. Countries that contribute the most pathogens to medical research are often the last to benefit from the outcomes.

Low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) in Africa, Southeast Asia and Latin America, where new pathogens often emerge, are expected to proactively share biological materials and genomic data with the world through the World Health Organization (WHO). However, countries that develop life-critical vaccines, therapeutics and diagnostics (VTDs) using that material are under no obligation to reciprocate with fair and timely access to these clinical products. Risks are shared; rewards are not.

Despite the proven human cost of this inequity, the historic WHO Pandemic Agreement (WPA), adopted in May 2025, still lacks the much-needed Pathogen Access and Benefit-Sharing (PABS) Annex. Without a binding legal framework to enforce fair sharing from samples to solutions, a coordinated global response to cross-border health crises will remain fraught with challenges.

The price of survival

A case in point is the infamous vaccine apartheid witnessed during the COVID-19 pandemic, which left LMICs grappling with prolonged vaccine shortages even as high-income countries, according to the People's Vaccine Alliance, hoarded more than half of global vaccine supplies despite representing only around 13-14% of the world's population.

The COVAX initiative delivered just around a fifth of its promised doses by mid-2021 and WHO's COVID-19 Technology Access Pool, meant to facilitate the sharing of intellectual property and manufacturing knowhow, drew a blank. Subsequent mutations of the COVID-19 virus resulted in an estimated 1.3 million preventable deaths, delayed recoveries and a whopping \$28 trillion, as per the IMF, in global economic losses.

COVID-19 isn't the only example: the life-saving Ebola drug, Inmazeb, whose estimated per-treatment cost based on procurement data came to a jaw-dropping \$6,900, was effectively beyond the reach of those survivors, in one of the world's poorest regions, who had helped make the treatment a reality through their blood samples and antibodies. When a new outbreak struck in September 2025, killing, as per the WHO, nearly 70% of those infected, all that the WHO could do amid rich countries stockpiling the drug for "emergencies" was to wait for limited donations from the manufacturer.

More recently, the bilateral health compacts signed by the U.S. with more than 15 African nations require them to share pathogens for 25 years in return for just five years of diminishing U.S. funding and nearly no commitments on product access.

PABS seeks to legally link



Call for change: Low- and middle-income countries where new pathogens often emerge, are expected to proactively share biological materials and genomic data with the world. However, countries that develop life-critical vaccines using that material are under no obligation to reciprocate. GETTY IMAGES

sample-sharing to guaranteed benefits, making it mandatory for pharmaceutical manufacturers to provide 20% of real-time VTD production to the WHO during declared pandemics, at least half of it for free and the remaining at reasonable prices. Besides making yearly monetary contributions, manufacturers would also need to transfer technology, build capacity and enable broader production in developing countries through licences.

Technical gaps

Recent Intergovernmental Working Group negotiations in Geneva, while narrowing certain technical gaps, have not been able to address fundamental disagreements around binding obligations on benefit-sharing, intellectual property and data traceability. With another round of negotiations slated to begin on April 27, the window to secure a meaningful agreement is closing fast. Pushing ahead with a partial framework would undermine global health cooperation and institutional trust, compelling developing countries to settle for asymmetrical health deals.

While PABS is backed by around 100 LMICs, including India, which represent nearly 80% of the world's population and have suffered the limitations of voluntary goodwill arrangements, opposition comes from developed countries, especially the European Union (EU), which are home to some of the world's largest pharmaceutical companies.

Proponents of PABS want tighter, enforceable rules and contractual provisions to govern the sharing of samples and benefits, whereas opponents favour voluntary mechanisms over binding contracts, arguing that the added bureaucracy and complexity arising from legal mandates could stifle research and

innovation. This, despite existing global systems – from environmental treaties to public health frameworks – already relying on standard legal instruments to balance access with incentives.

The EU's current model of allowing anonymous access to pathogen sequence data without adequate transparency or traceability is opposed by PABS proponents, who say mandatory user registration is critical for greater accountability. The EU contends that doing so will impede the openness and interoperability of data systems. However, the likes of the European Genome-Phenome Archive, and the Global Initiative on Sharing All Influenza Data (GISAID), often publicly defended by many EU countries, already use secure access and trackable data-sharing systems.

Advocates of PABS want it to be made mandatory for companies and labs to let WHO and its programmes use their products and technologies developed using shared pathogen data under non-exclusive licences so that multiple players can produce and distribute those products and technologies. In contrast, the EU wants this arrangement to be left to the discretion of individual companies.

Supporters of PABS want all agreements to be made public and seek assured representation for civil society in negotiations and systemic oversight. The EU is averse to any such mechanisms. Additionally, PABS supporters want the scope of benefit-sharing to be extended beyond pandemics to include WHO's more frequent PHEIC (public health emergencies of international concern) declarations.

The middle ground

The EU's position is also being challenged by global health groups including the

AIDS Healthcare Foundation, Third World Network and Public Citizen. It is evident, however, that both sides ultimately seek certainty. While developing countries are seeking guaranteed, enforceable benefits, high-income countries, largely at the behest of their pharmaceutical industries, are looking for a legally predictable system that does not weigh down their innovation economics with obligations.

A middle ground for countries to share in the benefits of better pandemic preparedness could be a tiered system with lower obligations during normal times, stronger commitments during pandemics, and a global fund to support poorer countries, sparing manufacturers a disproportionate burden.

For a start, essential elements of access, utilisation, benefit-sharing, IP, onward transfer, dispute resolution and non-compliance could be written into the Annex now and detailed model contracts could be fleshed out over a mutually agreeable timeframe. A mechanism could be worked out to reward, not coerce, manufacturers who share IP.

Developed countries must reassess the impact of their resistance on their credibility with the Global South, while developing countries must show greater flexibility on timelines and payment terms in return for firm commitments on the essentials.

From zoonotic threats such as mpox, to engineered pathogens, dual-use biotech and AI-driven cyberbiosecurity risks, the next pandemic may not be too far off. When they meet again in Geneva, both sides must approach the resolution of the PABS impasse as a matter of political will rather than mere bargaining, for no one is safe until everyone is.

(Harsh Kabra is an independent journalist and commentator. harshkabra@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Countries that contribute the most pathogens to medical research are often the last to benefit from the outcomes. Despite the proven human cost of this inequity, the historic WHO Pandemic Agreement (WPA), adopted in May 2025, still lacks the much-needed Pathogen Access and Benefit-Sharing (PABS) Annex

PABS seeks to legally link sample-sharing to guaranteed benefits, making it mandatory for pharmaceutical manufacturers to provide 20% of real-time VTD production to the WHO during declared pandemics, at least half of it for free and the remaining at reasonable prices

While PABS is backed by around 100 LMICs, including India, which represent nearly 80% of the world's population and have suffered the limitations of voluntary goodwill arrangements, opposition comes from developed countries, especially the European Union (EU), which are home to some of the world's largest pharmaceutical companies

Liver disease often goes unnoticed in people with type 2 diabetes

Athira Elssa Johnson

A large proportion of people living with type 2 diabetes develop fatty liver, and nearly one in three may have underlying liver fibrosis without symptoms. Latest evidence published in *The Lancet*, from a large multinational European study of over 30,000 adults shows that undiagnosed liver fibrosis is relatively common, with about 4.6% having significant liver stiffness and 1.6% confirmed cases.

The study found strong links with metabolic factors such as obesity and type 2 diabetes, along with harmful alcohol use, with fatty liver disease accounting for over 90% of cases.

Fat accumulation to fibrosis

Type 2 diabetes is characterised by insulin resistance, which disrupts the metabolism of glucose, fat, and proteins. And one of the consequences is fat accumulation in the liver, known as hepatic steatosis.

According to Arulprakash S,



On the lookout: Liver disease in type 2 diabetes often remains undetected for years. Screening is therefore essential. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

clinical lead and senior consultant, Medical Gastroenterology and Hepatology, SRM Prime Hospital, this fat may remain harmless in some individuals. While it can infect liver cells in some cases, leading to inflammation (steatohepatitis), which can gradually progress to fibrosis and cirrhosis. He notes that genetic predisposition plays a role,

and also not everyone living with fatty liver develops advanced disease.

Vaibhav Patil, consultant, Hepatology and Medical Gastroenterology, Liver Disease and Transplantation, Rela Hospital, explains that insulin resistance is the central cause. It leads to fat deposition in liver cells and attracts

inflammatory cells, causing chronic inflammation and fibrosis. Additional contributors include high free fatty acids causing lipotoxicity, glycated proteins, and disturbances in gut microbiota. Metabolic conditions such as obesity, dyslipidaemia, and hypothyroidism further accelerate liver damage by increasing the flow of harmful fats to the liver. These conditions often coexist with diabetes and act together in disease progression.

Late symptoms

Liver disease in type 2 diabetes often remains undetected for years. As doctors point out, slow liver injury does not produce symptoms and is usually picked up only through investigations such as blood tests, ultrasound, or FibroScan.

Dr. Vaibhav Patil notes that the liver has a high functional reserve and lacks pain receptors, which delays the appearance of symptoms even in the presence of fibrosis.

Leelavathy Kandaswamy, Senior Consultant Diabetology and Endocrinologist, Apollo Speciality

Hospitals, explains that patients may feel normal despite ongoing damage. Symptoms such as fatigue, jaundice, abdominal swelling, or fluid accumulation typically appear only in advanced stages, when significant liver injury has already occurred.

Need for routine screening

Fatty liver is often reversible with strict glycaemic control and lifestyle modification. However, fibrosis represents a more advanced and largely irreversible stage of liver damage.

Doctors emphasise that fibrosis, not just fat accumulation, is the key determinant of long-term outcomes. It can lead to cirrhosis, liver failure, and hepatocellular carcinoma. They highlight the entity of "lean NASH," particularly seen in developing countries, where individuals who are not overweight still develop fatty liver due to genetic predisposition and visceral fat deposition. This underscores that being thin does not eliminate risk.

Fibrosis can also arise from other causes, including chronic viral

infections such as hepatitis B or C, drug-induced liver injury, heavy metal toxicity, and genetic conditions like Wilson disease or haemochromatosis.

Screening is therefore essential. Studies show that up to 35% of people with type 2 diabetes may have fibrosis without symptoms. Tests such as liver function tests, fibrosis scoring systems (including FIB-4), and non-invasive tools like FibroScan help detect early changes. Monitoring measures such as the CAP score can assess fat content in the liver.

Early detection helps in timely interventions, including weight management, improved blood sugar and lipid control, and medications such as pioglitazone or GLP-1 receptor agonists like semaglutide. Doctors therefore emphasise that integrating liver screening into routine diabetes care can help prevent progression to advanced disease and reduce the risk of long-term complications, including liver cancer.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of drug offenders detained under PIT-NDPS Act

34 Shimla district police have detained 34 accused under the PIT-NDPS Act so far this year as part of a crackdown on habitual drug traffickers. A repeat offender was recently held under preventive detention provisions to curb further narcotics-related activities, officials said. ANI

Temperatures soar past heatwave threshold in Odisha

44 In degrees celsius. The mercury touched 44 degrees Celsius at two locations — Jharsuguda and Talcher — in Odisha as heatwave conditions persisted, with 24 places recording temperatures of 40°C or above and authorities issuing advisories and school schedule changes. PTI

Infosys posts strong quarterly profit growth for Jan.-March quarter

21 in per cent. IT major Infosys reported a 21% increase in net profit to ₹8,501 crore for the January-March quarter, driven by growth in key sectors, even as the company flagged global economic uncertainties and projected modest revenue growth of 1.5-3.5% for FY27. PTI

Africa projected to face major fuel shortfall risk by 2040

86 In million tonnes. Africa is projected to face a fuel shortfall of 86 million tonnes by 2040, according to a report by the Africa Finance Corporation. It warned that the continent's heavy reliance on imported refined fuel leaves it vulnerable to global supply disruptions. AFP

SAI allocates funds for Thomas, Uber Cup teams

1.45 In ₹ crore. The Sports Authority of India has sanctioned over ₹1.45 crore in financial and logistical assistance for a 34 member Indian contingent participating in the Thomas and Uber Cup Finals in Denmark. ANI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What are safer fireworks alternatives?

How loud do fireworks at Thrissur Pooram get? What do India's noise rules permit? What risks do fireworks pose to hospitals? What is cold spark technology? Are they safer than traditional fireworks? Why are noiseless alternatives not widely used yet? What transition is being proposed for Thrissur Pooram?

EXPLAINER

Divva Gandhi

The story so far:

As hundreds gathered to experience the grand fireworks display at the Thrissur Pooram festival in Kerala last year, a heavily caparisoned and disoriented elephant, Uttoly Raman, suddenly ran amok, leaving 42 people injured. The previous day, another parading elephant, Chirakkara Sreeraman, had attacked its mahout. “Elephants, like other animals, get disoriented not just by decibel levels, but also by the structure and frequency of noise,” said Manjari Jain, Associate Professor, Department of Biological Sciences, IISER Mohali. In response to an RTI request filed by *The Hindu*, the Kerala State Pollution Control Board stated that noise levels during the 2025 festival peaked at as much as 122.4 decibels in one area. This was just under the Central Pollution Control Board's ‘Noise Standards for Firecrackers’, which prohibit “the manufacture, sale or use of fire-crackers generating noise level exceeding 125 [decibels]... at 4 metres distance from the point of bursting.”

What are the risks to hospitals?

As for permissible ambient noise levels, the National Ambient Noise Monitoring Network recommends 45-55 decibels in residential areas and 40-50 decibels in “silence zones” such as hospitals and educational institutions — far lower than the legal cap of 125 decibels for fireworks.

Eminent social scientist Rajan Gurukkal has raised concerns about the proximity of Thrissur's fireworks to hospitals, especially those with neonatal intensive care units, and their impact on infant brain development. “The way the



Firefighters douse a blaze at a fireworks unit in Mundathikode, Thrissur, Kerala on April 21. PTI

festival is conducted in Thrissur violates ICU norms. Many facilities do not have soundproof windows, and the district hospital is minutes away from the fireworks,” he told *The Hindu*. The World Health Organization notes that noise pollution is the third most hazardous environmental threat to human health, after air and water pollution.

What are the noiseless alternatives?

“It is time to go noiseless,” said Professor Gurukkal, on April 21, when 13 people were killed and 40 injured in a blaze at a fireworks manufacturing unit in Mundathikode near Thrissur. “We do not need to reinvent the wheel, cold spark technology is available, but not yet scaled up.”

This technology, unlike traditional fireworks, uses a chemical combustion reaction of very fine granulated metal

alloy powders of titanium and zirconium, explained Samrat Ghosh, Assistant Professor at the Frugal Innovation Lab for Societal Benefit, Department of Chemical Sciences.

The ‘cold sparkular’, for instance, is a gun-like device equipped with a heater and a fan. The heater warms the fine alloy powder to increase its activation energy, while the fan blows the fine granulated metal alloy powders out. “When these fine powders eject out of the barrel of the hand-held gun, the heated fine powder reacts with the oxygen in the air and undergoes a rapid exothermic reaction that emits light with a sparkler-like effect as seen in traditional fireworks — but with no noise,” Dr. Ghosh explained.

They can prevent burn injuries. While traditional sparklers emit temperatures of around 1,200 °C, cold sparkulars and cold anars operate at 60-100°C, he added.

Though already available commercially online, these pyrotechnics remain expensive — a single ‘cold anar’ can cost around ₹400 — and are largely manufactured in China. “We have plenty of scope in India as the technology is well known and one can indigenously make these nano-powders,” Dr. Ghosh said.

Prof. Gurukkal emphasised that what is needed is “professionalism and management.” Contemporary stage technologies show that we can create in-house spark fountains and colourful spark-circles on the floor, he said, adding that televisions routinely employ cold spark systems that generate bright, upward jets of sparkling light without explosive combustion, heavy smoke and high-decibels “but giving the same, if not a superior, visual effect”.

“It is possible to deploy arrays of dozens or hundreds of spark units across open grounds, arranged linearly, radially, or in clusters, with sequential triggering of waves, expanding bursts, and cascading effects,” he said. These could even be mounted on temporary towers to extend the visual field, “creating the illusion of vertical expansion into the night sky”.

What is the way forward?

Delhi, which celebrated its loudest Diwali in three years, could also benefit from cold spark technology. As for Thrissur, Prof. Gurukkal said there should be an incremental transition strategy in Kerala, but that it would be ideal “to start with the Thrissur Pooram, the greatest among occasions that use parasols of intense air pollution with sound and smoke”.

Initial integration of large-scale cold spark-based displays should be tested in Thrissur, the district famed in the country for its high-quality air, he said. “It is the responsibility of the Thrissur Corporation to substitute the existing method.”

THE GIST

▼ Noise levels at Thrissur Pooram peaked at 122.4 decibels — close to the legal cap — raising concerns over risks to animals, hospitals, and infant brain development.

▼ Experts call for a shift to noiseless alternatives like cold spark technology, which can deliver similar visual effects without high decibel levels, smoke, or burn injuries.

What Telangana’s survey shows about caste inequality

When caste is measured, the gap is not incremental but exponential, with SC and ST households structurally locked in despite economic growth

Srinivas Goli

For decades, Indian policymakers have relied on income as the measure of disadvantage. A landmark government report from Telangana, based on one of the largest population surveys ever conducted in the country, offers a stark correction: when caste itself is measured, the gap is not incremental — it is exponential.

The Telangana Socio-Economic, Educational, Employment, Political and Caste (SEEEPC) Survey 2024, a cross-sectional, census-scale enumeration covering 97% of the State's population (35 million people), introduces a rigorous Composite Backwardness Index (CBI). The findings, published in a government report funded by the Government of Telangana with no external conflicts of interest, show that Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) are not merely “disadvantaged.” They are structurally locked in.

A gap too wide to ignore

Using 57 main questions along with several sub-questions, administered

through household visits across the State, the survey calculated CBI scores on a scale where higher values indicate greater backwardness. The results are stark.

An SC community scores 96 out of 100 on the backwardness index, while a general caste (GC) community scores 31. In other words, by the government's own multidimensional metric — covering education, occupation, living conditions, assets, and social integration — the average SC household is three times more backward than the average upper-caste household. The gap is not a margin of error; it is a chasm.

Perhaps the most politically consequential finding concerns scale. The survey assessed 242 distinct castes across Telangana. Of these, 135 castes, a staggering 67% of the State's population, recorded a CBI score higher than the State average.

The report explicitly notes that “not all backward castes are equally backward.” There is significant heterogeneity within the Backward Classes category: some groups score close to SCs, while others approach GC levels. This finding destroys the utility of treating any broad category, SC, ST, or BC, as a monolith. Policy

Telangana is among India's fastest-growing States. Yet the SEEEPC Survey 2024 proves that economic growth and caste inequality operate on separate tracks

cannot be one-size-fits-all.

Inequality across spaces and systems

The survey disaggregates outcomes across rural and urban areas. While urbanisation improves absolute outcomes, a Dalit family in Hyderabad may fare better than one in a remote village. However, urban-rural disparities persist sharply in education, income, and housing quality. Upper castes disproportionately benefit from city growth, while SC/ST households remain concentrated in urban informal settlements with amenities barely superior to rural slums.

The survey also identifies high educational backwardness among ST communities, even relative to SCs. This suggests that tribal communities face distinct barriers, including geographic isolation, language, and cultural distance

from mainstream institutions, that require targeted, not generic, interventions.

What the data demands from policy

The Independent Expert Working Group behind the SEEEPC report is unequivocal in its recommendations. The single most crucial lever is education — but not merely access.

“Strengthening government school systems and ensuring quality education is crucial,” the report states. This is a pointed rebuke to the current policy obsession with school enrolment (which has improved) over learning outcomes (which remain abysmal for disadvantaged castes). Without functional, high-quality government schools in SC/ST-majority areas, the cycle of occupational segmentation documented in the SEEEPC report will continue across generations for some more time.

The report is not without limitations. The data are self-reported, which may introduce bias: respondents could under-report discrimination or misrepresent social practices. Moreover, certain forms of untouchability were not explicitly captured, suggesting that the extent of social exclusion may be even greater than documented.

Growth without equity

Telangana is among India's fastest-growing States. Its GDP is rising, its cities are expanding, and poverty rates are declining.

Yet the SEEEPC Survey proves that economic growth and caste inequality operate on separate tracks. An SC household remains three times more backward than a GC household, not because of income but due to structural

A pattern of inequality

The SEEEPC Survey reveals wide gaps across castes, occupations, and outcomes

Table 1. Composite Backwardness Index (CBI) by social group

Social group	Mean CBI score	Relative backwardness (vs. General Castes)
Scheduled Castes (SC)	96	3.1x more backward
Scheduled Tribes (ST)	95	3.0x more backward
Backward Classes (BC)	86	2.7x more backward
General Castes (GC)	31	Reference (1.0x)

Table 2. Population share of backwardness

Category	Number of castes	Share of State population
Castes more backward than State average	135	67%
Castes less backward than State average	107	33%

Table 3. Occupational distribution by social group

Occupation	SC/ST	BC	GC
Agricultural labour	High	Moderate	Low
Informal work	High	Moderate	Low
Salaried/formal jobs	Low	Moderate	High

exclusion embedded in education, labour markets, and social systems.

The message to policymakers is simple: income-based targeting has failed the math test. Only caste-sensitive, multidimensional, and rigorously targeted interventions, beginning with government schools, can begin to close a gap of this magnitude.

(Srinivas Goli is an Associate Professor of Fertility and Social Demography at the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS), Mumbai. Views are Personal)

FULL CONTEXT

Real equity gap in higher education

Equity in higher education institutions is more constrained by gaps in representation in employment than in admissions; the UGC regulations focus largely on anti-discrimination and complaint-resolution mechanisms, but do not adequately address these structural gaps



According to data submitted by the UGC to a parliamentary panel and the Supreme Court, 378 complaints were reported by Equal Opportunity Cells and SC/ST Cells in 2023-24 across 704 universities and 1,553 colleges. GETTY IMAGES

Anish Gupta

The new University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) Regulations, 2026, have sparked considerable debate and protests within academic circles and among the general public, both in support of and in opposition. Although the Supreme Court has stayed their implementation, observing that they are vague and potentially open to misuse, the issue has raised several important academic questions – particularly regarding the empirical aspects of equity, discrimination, and caste-based crimes.

Equity in HEIs
One of the most important measures of equity is the representation of various social groups in employment and education at different levels within HEIs. A look at **Table 1**, based on the UGC Annual Report 2023, reveals four key trends in Central universities.

First, compared to the constitutionally mandated reservations for SC (15%), ST (7.5%), and OBCs (27%), the share of these social groups across all levels of teaching and non-teaching jobs is lower. Second, this gap is larger at higher levels of employment than at lower levels. Third, unlike in employment, representation in admissions at all levels (UG, PG, M.Phil, and Ph.D.) for all social groups is more or less close to the reservation mandated by the Constitution. Fourth, encouragingly, ST representation in admissions is 1.5 to 2.7 times higher than the mandated level, except at the undergraduate level, where it is slightly lower.

Overall, this suggests that, at the macro level, inequity is more of a problem in employment than in admissions.

It is worth noting that gaps in admissions can be filled within a year, but the same is not true for employment. Even with the strict implementation of reservations, bridging this gap will take many years, as it depends on the retirement of employees who were appointed when reservations were not properly implemented.

Data on discrimination in HEIs
Comprehensive data on discrimination-related complaints across all social groups in HEIs is not available, limiting objective and comparable analysis. However, according to data submitted by the UGC to a parliamentary panel and the Supreme Court, 378 complaints were reported by Equal Opportunity Cells (EOCs) and SC/ST Cells in 2023-24 across 704 universities and 1,553 colleges.

Since a breakdown of EOC complaints

An uneven ladder

Employment lags behind admissions, while limited data shapes understanding of discrimination and crime.

Table 1: Category wise non teaching, teaching staff and admissions in 2023-24

Non-teaching staff	SC	ST	OBC
Group A	5.9	3.9	7.9
Group B	10.7	5.2	12.1
Group C	10.5	6.2	14.4
Teaching staff	SC	ST	OBC
Professor	8.8	2.2	7.2
Associate Professor	9.2	2.9	9.1
Assistant Professor	12.5	6.1	19.3
Admissions in First year	SC	ST	OBC
UG	13.6	5.6	25.6
PG	10.5	16.5*	24.5
M.Phil.	16.7*	11.7*	29.7
Ph.D.	11.4	20.0*	25.9

Source: UGC Annual Report 2023-24

by social groups is unavailable, a holistic assessment is constrained. Nonetheless, even if one assumes that all EOC complaints are caste-based, the total number of such cases amounts to approximately 3.7 per one lakh students and about 0.16 per institution (assuming an average enrolment of 4,000 students per HEI). Moreover, the disposal rate for complaints related to SC/ST issues was as high as 90%, an important and often overlooked point.

NCRB data on caste-based crimes
Data on crimes against SCs and STs are published by the NCRB, which classifies all crimes committed against these groups by “Others” as caste-based crimes, which is not accurate. Moreover, the NCRB reports only those crimes against SCs and STs committed by individuals outside these communities. It does not provide disaggregated data on crimes occurring within SC and ST communities, as well as comparable data for other social groups. This limits the scope of comparative analysis.

According to NCRB data for 2023, crimes against SCs and STs committed by “Others” account for about 0.9% and 0.2% of total recorded crimes, respectively. However, given the limitations of the available data, it may be assumed that the distribution of crimes committed against different social groups broadly reflects their share in the population.

Assuming that crime distribution broadly reflects population shares, SCs (16.6%) and STs (8.6%) would account for 16.6 and 8.6 crimes out of every 100, respectively, with the remaining 74.8 attributed to Others.

It follows from this proportional exercise that the likelihood of a person

Table 2: Crime/ atrocity against SC/ST in India in 2023

Social group of victim	Social group of accused	Crime incidence	% of total crime	Crime rate	Charge-sheeting rate	% Population
Crime against SC	Others	57,789	0.9	28.7	81.2	SC- 16.6
	SC/ST	Na	Na	Na	Na	
Crime against ST	Others	12,960	0.2	12.4	79.5	ST- 8.6
	SC/ST	Na	Na	Na	Na	
Crime against Others	Others	Na	Na	Na	Na	Others- 74.8 Na
	SC/ST	Na	Na	Na	Na	
Crime against all	All	62,41,569	100	270.3	72.7	100

Source: Crime in India 2021-23, NCRB



belonging to SC/ST committing a crime against someone belonging to the SC is roughly 52 times higher than that of a person from other groups. Similarly, the likelihood of a person belonging to SC/ST committing a crime against someone belonging to the ST is roughly 125 times higher than that of a person from other groups.

If we go by the assumption that the share of crimes against SC and ST exceeds their population share, any such excess would necessarily be reflected in crimes occurring within SC/ST communities, since the share of crimes committed by Others is already known and fixed.

Issue of underreporting
An important caveat is the underreporting of crimes, especially against SC and ST, by Others. However, even if one assumes, purely hypothetically, that the actual number of such crimes is 100 times the reported figure (an extremely high multiplier), the likelihood of crimes against SC and ST committed by members of their own communities would still be 3.2 and 14.3 times higher, respectively, than those committed by Others.

Moreover, chargesheeting rates in cases involving crimes against SC and ST are 81.2% and 79.5%, respectively, compared to an overall average of 72.7%. This suggests comparatively stronger procedural follow-through in cases involving crimes against SC and ST than in Others.

These results are not surprising, as crimes tend to occur among individuals in close social and geographic proximity. Conversely, a very low crime rate against a particular social group, compared to the average, may indicate social segregation rather than harmony.

Problems with the regulations
The regulations suffer from three major shortcomings. First, the analysis suggests that the primary challenge in HEIs lies in achieving equity in employment – particularly at leadership levels – rather

than in admissions or reported discrimination.

Second, the regulations seem to confuse equity with anti-discrimination.

Equity entails providing targeted support to ensure fair outcomes, whereas anti-discrimination focuses on identifying and penalising discriminatory conduct, typically through complaint-resolution mechanisms. Interestingly, the title refers to “promotion of equity” and the preamble emphasises both equity and eradication of discrimination, the operative provisions, particularly points 4 (Duty to Promote Equity), 6 (Equity Helpline), and 7 (Measures for Promotion of Equity), are confined largely to the latter. Third, the regulations appear to assume the complete elimination of crimes based on identities. While desirable, this is unrealistic without a broader reduction in overall crime. Overly stringent measures may even risk reinforcing social segregation.

What can be done?
Efforts should focus on promoting equity by increasing the representation of reserved categories in employment in HEIs, especially at higher levels, while fostering integration across social groups. Over time, growing interactions may lead the rate of crime against SC/ST to converge with the average crime rate, which could initially result in some increase in reported cases against SC/ST. Therefore, reducing the general crime rate, rather than addressing crimes in isolation, is essential for strengthening social cohesion and building a more inclusive environment.

Since HEIs shape societal values, the UGC should promote measures that foster mutual respect and understanding, while curbing student politics that encourage factionalism and teach young minds to exploit every opportunity for narrow or petty gains. (Anish Gupta teaches Economics at the Delhi School of Economics. The author acknowledges the inputs received from Prerona Baruah of IEDS, Noida)

THE DAILY QUIZ

After a day of hectic polling in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, here is a quiz on Chief Ministers from these States

Srinivasan Ramani

QUESTION 1
West Bengal's first Chief Minister was a veteran freedom fighter with roots in the Anushilan Samiti and he served very briefly before being succeeded by one of the State's longer serving CMs. Name them both.

QUESTION 2
When Jyoti Basu – the Chief Minister who served the longest tenure in West Bengal – was first elected in the State Assembly, he was just one of three MLAs elected on the Communist Party of India ticket. Who among the other two, was elected from Darjeeling?

QUESTION 3
Ajoy Mukherjee, who served as West

Bengal CM three times in the late 1960s and early 70s, founded a party that launched the political career of a future President of India. Name the party and the future President.

QUESTION 4
When Tamil thespian Sivaji Ganesan fiercely raged against social orthodoxy in the film, Parasakthi, he was orating dialogue written by a prolific screenwriter who also served as the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu for many years across terms. Name him.

QUESTION 5
Name this Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu who was a school topper, went on to win the State government's top merit scholarship and could have joined law college, but chose a career in cinema.



Visual Question:
Identify this popular CM from Tamil Nadu who played a major role in instituting the mid-day meal scheme in schools in Tamil Nadu.

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. The original idea was conceived in 1922 to celebrate the works of which famous Spanish author? **Ans: Miguel de Cervantes** 2. Why was April 23 chosen as the English Language Day? **Ans: The date is traditionally observed as both the birthday and date of death of William Shakespeare** 3. What does the term 'incunabula' refer too? **Ans: Books, pamphlets, and broadsides printed in Europe before 1501** 4. What are the terms used for: (i): a quote at the beginning of the book or chapter and (ii): illustration facing the title page? **Ans: Epigraph and Frontispiece** 5. What is it a technical term for? **Ans: Lung disease caused by fine silica dust** 6. From which Indian languages do the English words bandicoot, catamaran and candy come? **Ans: Bandicoot from Telugu, catamaran from Tamil and candy from Sanskrit** 7. Which were the last two letters added to the modern English alphabet? **Ans: U and J** Visual: This a page from the oldest known dated printed book in the world. **Ans: Diamond Sutra** **Early Birds:** Prem raj P. | Tito Shiladitya | Piyali Tuli | Sukdev Shet | Aaryan Dhaker



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

How is the word ‘Wednesday’ pronounced? (Dr. N. Ananthkumar Babu, Visakhapatnam)
Native speakers of English do not pronounce the ‘d’ in this word. ‘Wedn’ is pronounced like the word ‘when’. The second ‘e’ is silent and the ‘s’ that follows is like the ‘z’ in words like ‘zip’, ‘zoo’, and ‘zing’. Many native speakers of English pronounce the ‘ay’ in ‘day’ like the ‘i’ in words like ‘fit’, ‘hit’, and ‘sit’. In fact, this is how they pronounce the ‘ay’ in Monday, Tuesday. I guess this explains how they get the lines of Solomon Grundy to rhyme. Some native speakers, however, pronounce the final syllable like the word ‘day’ – like we Indians do.

For native speakers of English, ‘Wednesday’ consists of only two syllables. The first syllable is ‘wenz’ and the second ‘day’. The stress is on the first syllable.

What is the meaning of the word ‘honcho’? (C. V. Srinivasamurthy, Chennai)
Honcho is slang for ‘boss’. When you refer to someone as being the ‘head honcho’, you mean that he/she is in charge. The word is mainly used in American English. The first ‘o’ is pronounced like the ‘o’ in ‘stop’, ‘pop’ and ‘top’, and the second ‘o’ is like the ‘o’ in ‘go’, ‘so’, and ‘no’. The stress is on the first syllable. The word should not be used in formal contexts.

Is it ok to use ‘How come’? (L. Surendran, Hospet, Karnataka)
Americans use the expression ‘How come’ in informal contexts to mean ‘why’. It is very common to hear Americans say:
How come you didn’t come to the party? (Why didn’t you come to the party?)
How come John isn’t here? (Why isn’t John here?)
How come you didn’t get the job? (Why didn’t you get the job?)
Although ‘How come’ is frequently used in informal speech, it is not acceptable in formal writing.

What is the meaning and origin of ‘to eat humble pie’? (P. Balachander, Kanyakumari)
When someone eats humble pie, they behave in a manner which makes it clear to everyone that they are willing to admit they were wrong about something.
After losing the elections, he was made to eat humble pie.
The pie in the original expression was ‘umble pie’ and not ‘humble pie’. The ‘umbles’ consisted of meat from the heart, liver and gizzard of deer.
The servants ate these portions of the meat because they were not considered to be the choicest meat. The best portions were reserved for the nobles. Therefore, a person who ate ‘umble pie’ was one in an inferior position; one who had to humble himself before someone who was superior.

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Word of the day

Chortle:
a soft partly suppressed laugh

Synonyms: giggle, chuckle, cackle

Usage: She began to chortle at the silly joke.

Pronunciation:
newsth.live/chortle

International Phonetic Alphabet: /tʃɔːtl̩/

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